

CITY: Pg 3

Malviya Nagar blaze reignites concerns over fire safety

NATION: Pg 5

'Nepal a priority partner': Modi

FILM: Pg 12

FWICE withdraws non-cooperation directive against Ranveer

LICENSED FOR 6, EXPANDED TO 25 | 12 OF 21 VICTIMS WERE FOREIGNERS

Checked in, never checked out: 21 killed in hotel inferno

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE



SEALED WINDOWS, SINGLE EXIT-ENTRY TRAP SCORES OF PEOPLE

Local people attempt to douse a fire at a hotel in New Delhi, on Wednesday

AP/PTI

LOCKED BY DESIGN, TRAPPED BY FIRE

» The building's basement housed an allegedly illegal restaurant and unauthorised guest accommodations, potentially increasing the risks and complicating evacuation during the emergency

» More than 40 people were rescued and rushed to nearby hospitals as thick smoke engulfed the multi-storey structure

» The tragedy, one of Delhi's deadliest hotel fires in recent years, unfolded inside Flourish Stay B&B and the adjoining Lemon Green Restaurant, where trapped guests desperately jumped from windows and terraces to escape thick smoke and flames

» The Prime Minister's Office announced an ex gratia of 2 lakh rupees from the Prime Minister's National Relief Fund for the next of kin of each deceased victim and 50,000 rupees for those injured

» Deeply saddened by the tragic loss of lives in the devastating fire incident in Malviya Nagar: Delhi CM

HOTEL BUILDING OWNER DETAINED

WOMAN JUMPS WITH CHILD TO ESCAPE FIRE

NEW DELHI: Several people, including a woman clutching a child, jumped from different floors of a five-storey south Delhi building where a massive fire broke out on Wednesday, as locals rushed to spread mattresses on the road below in a desperate attempt to save lives. As thick black smoke billowed out of the windows and flames rapidly spread through the building, panic-stricken occupants were seen smashing window panes, leaning out of openings and desperately calling for help. **See P3**

ORDINARY HEROES & AN EXTRAORDINARY RESCUE

NEW DELHI: There was no moment to spare and the urgency was not lost on the locals who broke glasses and rushed with blankets to save the patrons escaping an inferno that tore through a bed-and-breakfast building in south Delhi's Malviya Nagar on Wednesday.

Anita Chaudhary, a local resident, said the entire area was sent into panic after sound of several blasts. "I heard multiple blast-like sounds and then screams from inside the building..." **See P3**

ATF lifeline:
Cabinet clears
Rs 10,000 cr

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Union Cabinet, chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, has approved a one-time budgetary support of up to Rs 10,000 crore to help stabilise Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF) prices for Scheduled Indian Airlines amid unprecedented volatility in global fuel markets triggered by the ongoing West Asia crisis.

Beginning with a government directive, funds flow to Oil Marketing Companies via the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas in the form of zero-interest advances. Stability in domestic and global flight operations remains the central focus, as price swings in aviation turbine fuel are absorbed by this mechanism. Under the approved mechanism, OMCs will be compensated whenever international ATF prices exceed a benchmark level. **See P10**

INDIA REMAINS ENGAGED IN TALKS

US trade salvo: 12.5% tariff proposal hits India, others

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA



LABOUR CONCERNS

» Reacting to the proposed 12.5 per cent tariff, the Union Commerce ministry said New Delhi is engaged with the US on the two Section 301 investigations - over concerns related to forced labour and excess industrial capacity

» The country is also 'parallelly' engaged with the US for finalisation of an interim trade agreement, a framework for which was announced through a joint statement on February 7

The US Trade Representative (USTR) has proposed the additional duty following investigations launched

Expelled TMC leader Ritabrata elected LoP, 58 rebel MLAs pledge support

TMC dissolves all party committees, frontal organisations

MPOST BUREAU



Ritabrata Banerjee addresses the media, in Kolkata, on Wednesday

PIC/GAUTAM BOSE

THE SPLIT

» 'We accept Mamata Banerjee as our leader but do not accept Abhishek Banerjee'

» Mamata Banerjee calls meet at her Kalighat residence on Wednesday

» The developments have now raised crucial questions over Mamata Banerjee's next move and which faction will ultimately gain control of the party symbol

party committees and frontal organisations across West Bengal within hours.

The rebel camp, led by

RBI dismisses gold sale rumours



SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: On Wednesday, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) snubbed media reports which claimed the central bank had sold part of its gold reserves. They made it clear that their gold holdings have not changed and asked people to stick to official information from the RBI.

In a statement, the RBI stated its gold stock remains steady at 880.52 tonnes. Details about their gold stash are always available in their Monthly Bulletin, too. This clarification followed recent scrutiny over India's foreign exchange reserves. There has been a notable bump in the value of India's gold holdings over the past year. As per the RBI's numbers - as of April 24, India's total forex reserves came in at US\$698.49 billion, which is down slightly from US\$703.31 billion the previous week.

Foreign Currency Assets (FCA), which form the largest component of the reserves, were valued at US\$554.62 billion. Gold reserves were valued at US\$120.24 billion, while Special Drawing Rights (SDRs) and the Reserve Tranche Position with the International Monetary Fund (IMF) stood at US\$18.77 billion and US\$4.86 billion, respectively. **See P10**

INDIA CONDEMNS STRIKE; URGES CIVILIAN SAFETY

Indian killed in Iranian attack on Kuwait Airport; MEA reacts

MPOST BUREAU

DUBAI: An Indian national was killed in an attack on Kuwait International Airport, the Indian Embassy in Kuwait said in a post on X on Wednesday. The attack wounded at least 63 other people, according to the Health Ministry.

"63 injured individuals were received and distributed among hospitals... This includes serious injuries... including head wounds, cerebral haemorrhages, amputations and injuries resulting from explosions," Health ministry spokesperson Abdullah

Kuwait Airways flights resumed from a different terminal from the one that was hit. No other flights would be operating

al-Sanad said, adding that 25 ambulances were dispatched to the airport.

The Indian Embassy in Kuwait expressed its condolences in a post on X. It stated that the mission is "closely

BENGAL LAUNCHES 'APNAR SORKAR APNAR PASHE' HELPLINE

CM: Annapurna Yojana funds reached 28.25 lakh beneficiaries in West Bengal

SOUMITRA NANDI



Suvendu Adhikari hands over a check of Annapurna Yojana to a beneficiary, in Kolkata, on Wednesday

PIC/GAUTAM BOSE

reach initiative, Apnar Sorkar Apnar Pashe.

According to official figures, Nadia recorded the highest number of beneficiaries at 2,59,955, followed by Murshidabad (2,19,373) and West Midnapore (2,17,856).

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ANNOUNCES FREE BUS PASS FOR STUDENTS, 10,000 YUVA SANGHAS

DK takes charge in Karnataka

MPOST BUREAU

BENGALURU: Senior Congress leader D K Shivakumar took oath as Karnataka Chief Minister on Wednesday, marking a change of guard in the state, and formally ending his long-drawn power tussle for the post with predecessor Siddaramaiah.

Governor Thaaawarchand Gehlot administered the oath of office and secrecy to Shivakumar at the Lok Bhavan and 13 other party legislators were also sworn in as ministers.

Soon after taking oath, in the presence of top leaders Mallikarjun Kharge, Rahul Gandhi, Shivakumar chaired his first cabinet



Newly-sworn Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar bows down on the steps of state Legislative Assembly as a sign of respect after the swearing-in ceremony of the new state government

PTI

meeting and announced youth-student-centric welfare initiatives including grant of free bus

pass for students and formation of 10,000 Bharat Jodo Yuva Sanghas to raise leadership quality

and build social harmony.

Clad in a silk kurta and dhoti, Shivakumar took **Continued on P4**

CHANGE OF GUARD

» Governor Thaaawarchand Gehlot administered the oath of office and secrecy to Shivakumar at the Lok Bhavan and 13 other party legislators were also sworn in as ministers

» Clad in a silk kurta and dhoti, Shivakumar took the oath in the name of the revered seer 'Gangadhar Ajja' while holding a copy of the Constitution

» He bowed, and paid obeisance to the gathering before taking the oath

» Senior Dalit MLA G Parameshwara, who will be the new Deputy CM, took oath in the name of Dr B R Ambedkar

Sourav Ganguly's security cover scaled down to 'Y' category from 'Z'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: The West Bengal government has scaled down the security cover of the former Indian cricket team captain Sourav Ganguly from 'Z' category to 'Y' category protection.

According to sources, the decision was implemented on Wednesday by the state's security wing, which follows a comprehensive state-wide review of VIP and VVIP security deployments and threat perception analysis.

Prior to May 2023, Gan-



guly was provided with 'Y' category security cover, which was upgraded to 'Z' category by the then state government.

The scaling down is part of a larger policy shift initiated by the newly formed state government led by Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari.

Administration officials indicated that the exercise aims to rationalise state expenditure and ensure that security resource allocation strictly aligns with an individual's current constitutional role and active threat assessment, rather than public status. **Continued on P4**

SAKET COLLAPSE

Owner earned Rs 10 lakh per month from 4 floors, planned 2 more levels

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Details emerging from the probe into the building collapse in Saket that killed six people have pointed to alleged illegal construction and financial gains behind the structure that came crashing down on May 30, with police claiming that the owner was planning to add two more floors despite the apparent violations.

According to sources, Karamveer (71), the building owner arrested in connection with the incident, told investigators that he was earning around Rs 10 lakh per month from the four floors of the building. Each floor had reportedly been rented out for about Rs 2.5 lakh per month.

The probe has revealed that two additional floors were under construction at the time of the collapse. Sources said Karamveer had already held discussions with the prospective buyers and investors about the proposed floors, from which he expected to earn an additional Rs 5 lakh per month.



During the debris clearance operation on Tuesday, police seized several electricity meters from the site, which were registered in Karamveer's name, as evidence. Officials believe the meters could serve as crucial documentary proof in establishing the ownership of the building and fixing responsibility for the construction.

Police have also begun contacting the tenants and occupants who had rented floors in the building. Notices are being issued to several people as the investigators seek details as to when the construction began, how many people were residing in the structure and whether the occupants had noticed any

signs of structural weakness before the collapse.

Sources said police have so far been unable to trace an approved building plan for the structure. If it is established that the building lacked sanctioned plans or was constructed in violation of the approved norms, criminal liability may extend beyond the owner to the other persons involved in the project, including the builder.

Meanwhile, efforts have intensified to trace the builder, Manish, who is absconding. According to sources, his last known location was traced to Dehradun, and a police team has been dispatched there to apprehend him.

Sandhu directs MCD to enforce bylaws & curb illegal structures

NEW DELHI: Days after the building collapse in Saket, Lt Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu has directed the MCD to strictly enforce building bylaws to curb illegal structural expansions in the city.

Sandhu chaired a high-level review meeting of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) on Tuesday to drive a comprehensive action plan for stronger urban governance, improved civic infrastructure, and enhanced structural safety across the capital, he said in a X post on Wednesday. The review was held following a building collapse in Saket on Saturday, that claimed six lives and left several injured. Several lapses related to the building have come to the fore even as the MCD has suspended two engineers over the incident.

Sandhu emphasised strict enforcement of building bylaws to curb illegal structural expansions and directed the MCD to implement a time-bound strategy to tackle unauthorised constructions decisively.

The LG also reviewed key civic priorities, including desilting of stormwater drains ahead of the monsoon, road and pavement repairs for dust mitigation, and intensified garbage clearance to strengthen sanitation standards, he posted.

Review of public welfare initiatives, with a focus on expediting the PM-UDAY scheme for residents of unauthorised colonies and finalising a participatory CSR framework for the rejuvenation of public parks were also held during the meeting. **MP05T**

3 states, 6 days: How Delhi Police cracked Rs 54.5 lakh robbery case

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A robbery of Rs 54.5 lakh reported by an employee of a money transfer agent in Old Delhi turned out to be a self-staged crime, an official said on Wednesday. Police arrested six people and recovered Rs 50 lakh after a multi-state manhunt spanning Delhi, Rajasthan and Uttarakhand.

The case came to light on May 26 when Vasudev (23), a resident of Rajasthan's Bikaner, who worked for a money transfer agent in Delhi, approached police claiming that two men robbed him of a bag containing Rs 54.5 lakh near Fatehpuri in the Chandni Chowk area.

The complainant said he was entrusted by his employer to deliver the cash to a money transfer office in Kucha Ghisiram. He alleged that after getting down from a Rapido auto near SPM Road around 11 am, two men attacked him, snatched the cash bag and his mobile phone, tore his shirt and fled towards Pul Mithai.

A case was registered under relevant provisions of the BNS, and an investigation was launched.

Police examined footage from more than 500 CCTV cameras and traced the route taken by the alleged robbers.



During scrutiny of the footage, investigators noticed several inconsistencies in Vasudev's version, the official said.

"The complainant neither resisted the robbers nor attempted to chase them. The suspects appeared to be waiting for a specific person and had information about cash movement. The complainant also changed his statements during questioning and even pretended to lose consciousness shortly after the incident," a senior police officer said.

Under sustained interrogation, Vasudev allegedly confessed that he had conspired with his cousin Purushottam and four others from Rajasthan to misappropriate the money by staging a robbery.

Police said Vasudev had informed his cousin about his job and the movement of large amounts of cash, and the group then hatched a plan to fake a robbery whenever he was assigned to deliver a substantial sum.

Investigators said four of the accused travelled to Delhi and stayed at a hotel in Sarai Rohilla before executing the plan. Two of them allegedly carried out the staged robbery, while the others remained nearby to provide support, they said.

Following the confession, police raided places in Rajasthan and Uttarakhand. Purushottam was apprehended from Rajasthan's Jalore district on May 28. Kamal Bharti and Manful Mund were arrested from Bikaner on May 29 and May 30, respectively.

Another accused, Manoj Motasara, was arrested from Uttarakhand's Roorkee on May 31, and Rs 16 lakh was recovered from him. The sixth accused, Ram Niwas, was arrested from a hotel in Nagaur, Rajasthan, on June 2, leading to the recovery of Rs 34 lakh.

Police said the six-day operation covered nearly 3,500 kilometres and involved extensive technical surveillance, CCTV analysis and interstate raids.

The accused have been identified as Vasudev, Purushottam, Ram Niwas, Kamal Bharti, Manful Mund and Manoj Motasara, all residents of Rajasthan. Further investigation is underway, and efforts are underway to recover the remaining amount, police said.

Home guard killed after truck rams into police checkpoint

GURUGRAM: A speeding truck rammed into a police checkpoint here leaving a home guard dead on the spot, police said on Wednesday.

The incident took place around 11.30 pm on Tuesday near World Mark Mall in Sector 65, where police personnel were on duty, they said.

According to eyewitnesses, the truck broke through the checkpoint and hit home guard Sandeep Kumar. A police vehicle was also damaged.

Kumar, a resident of Liwasi village in Bhiwani district, had been transferred from Bhiwani to Gurugram three days ago, officials said.

"After the incident, the police on duty tried to nab the driver, but he took advantage of the darkness and fled, abandoning the truck at the spot," a senior police officer said.

The truck has been seized, and raids are underway to arrest him soon, the officer said. The body has been sent for post-mortem and the deceased's family has been informed, the police added. **PTI**

Report: 75.78% of Capital's area heat-stressed for 6 or more yrs

NEW DELHI: About 75.78 per cent of Delhi's area remained heat-stressed for six or more years between 2015 and 2024, with a majority of construction sites, marketplaces and schools located in areas experiencing recurring extreme heat, according to a report by the Centre for Science and Environment (CSE).

The report, titled "Making Delhi Heat-Resilient: A Roadmap with the Focus on Vulnerable Groups", said that 98.72 per cent of Delhi's total area crossed the heat-stress threshold at least once during the decade.

According to the study, 92 per cent of construction projects are located in areas where land surface temperatures crossed the 45 degrees Celsius threshold at least once between 2015 and 2024, while 77 per cent are in areas witnessing recurring extreme heat.

About 84 per cent of the 643 mapped marketplaces, including major mandis, are situated in areas experiencing recurrent heat stress, while 76 per cent of mapped informal settlements housing nearly 1.32 million people are located in heat-stressed localities, it said.

The report also found



that 80 per cent of the 1,066 schools mapped in the city are located in heat-stressed areas. It identified 35 wards, including Matiala, Kakraula, Narela and Chandni Chowk, as having "very high" to "high" cumulative vulnerability.

According to the report, 153 of Delhi's 272 wards have more than 75 per cent of their area exposed to recurring heat stress, while 82 wards have more than 90 per cent of their area under heat stress. Seventeen wards have their entire area under heat stress.

The report said Delhi faces a deepening crisis from rising temperatures, with "feels-like" temperatures reaching as high as 52 degrees Celsius in 2025. It noted that 25 heat-related deaths were reported in the city in 2024 by the Union Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, while independent reports put

the number at more than 55.

It added that Delhi is shifting towards a "new and warmer normal", with increases observed in both annual average maximum and minimum temperatures over the past four decades.

Delhi's ability to cool down at night has reduced by 9 per cent, the report said, adding that the city's core cools 3.8 degrees Celsius less than its peri-urban counterparts, causing heat stress to be retained round the clock in dense, concrete-heavy neighbourhoods.

Areas identified as persistently heat-stressed include the walled city and its extensions, Karol Bagh, Kashmere Gate ISBT and its surroundings, Connaught Place (inner circle), Uttam Nagar, Palam, Dabri, Najafgarh, Kanjhawala, Budh Vihar, Bawana and Narela.

A CSE study found large parts of Delhi facing severe heat stress, with temperatures crossing 60 degree Celsius in some locations. Declining green cover, expanding urbanisation and vulnerable populations have intensified risks, prompting calls for heat-resilient planning and expanded green spaces. **PTI**

Police nabs man for killing son born out of live-in relationship

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: Gurugram Police has arrested a man for allegedly poisoning and killing his 5-month-old son born out of a live-in relationship as he was reportedly unhappy about the child's birth, officials said on Tuesday.

An FIR was filed last year based on a complaint filed by the deceased child's mother and the accused's live-in partner, and police have now arrested the accused.

According to police, on January 5 last year, they received information that a 5-month-old child had been taken to a hosp for treatment, where doctors declared him dead.

"The child's mother said in her complaint that she had been in a live-in relationship with a man since 2023 and that a male child was born from their relationship

"The woman said there were frequent disputes with her partner after the

HIGHLIGHTS

- » According to police, on January 5 last year, they received information that a 5-month-old child had been taken to a hosp for treatment, where doctors declared him dead
- » The child's mother said in her complaint that she had been in a live-in relationship with a man since 2023 and that a male child was born from their relationship
- » The woman said there were frequent disputes with her partner after the



child's birth. On January 5, 2025, her partner took the child with him and returned some time later, saying the boy was unwell, police stated

» The woman alleged that her live-in partner had either administered a poisonous substance...

The woman alleged that her live-in partner had either administered a poisonous substance or caused the death of her 5-month-old son by some other means, police said.

After a long investigation, police arrested the accused, Vikramjeet (23), a resident of Hisar district in Haryana, in Gurugram on Monday, police said. "During interrogation, it was revealed that the accused, who was married, started liv-

ing with the complainant in 2023. A child was born out of the relationship, leading to frequent disputes between them.

"The accused was unhappy about the birth of the child and had also pressured his partner to terminate the pregnancy. The accused has disclosed that he administered a poisonous substance to the 5-month-old child, resulting in his death," a Gurugram Police spokesperson said.

Three held in Rs 42.9 lakh digital arrest case in GGM

GURUGRAM: Three men have been arrested in connection with a Rs 42.92 lakh digital arrest case here, while two other accused were earlier arrested in the same case, police said on Wednesday.

According to the police, on May 12, a person filed a complaint stating that between May 7 and May 11, an individual posing as a CBI officer digitally arrested him and, through intimidation and threats, fraudulently induced him to transfer a total of Rs 42.92 lakh via RTGS.

Based on the complaint, a case was registered under the relevant sections at the Cyber Crime Police Station (West), they added.

The accused were identified as Suhail Akhtar, Anas Ansari and Usman, residents of Roorkee, Haridwar in Uttarakhand. Akhtar and Ansari were arrested from Roorkee on June 2, while Usman was arrested from Roorkee on June 3, the police said.

Earlier, two other accused, Avdhesh, a resident of Village Kinana, District Jind

and Manoj Kumar, a resident of Rewari in Haryana, were arrested on May 17 in connection with the same case.

"During police interrogation, it was revealed that Avdhesh, Kumar and Akhtar were the account holders into whose bank accounts the defrauded money was transferred. In return, they received payment for allowing their accounts to be used," the police said.

Ansari and Usman allegedly withdrew the cash on commission and handed it over to another person. **MP05T**

NEW DELHI: Despite the government's efforts, the water crisis continues in the city, affecting supply in several parts of the national capital, Delhi Jal Board officials said on Wednesday.

For more than a fortnight now, the city has been facing a severe water crisis affecting supply in parts of the national capital as the Yamuna River at Wazirabad falls almost five feet below normal.

"The situation remains the same as earlier. In the last 24 hours, the average water pro-

duction was around 923 million gallons per day (MGD). The river stream has dried, affecting our water production till the time there is rainfall in upper catchment areas of Yamuna, the situation is likely to remain the same," a senior DJB officer said.

According to the officials, production continues to remain low at two of DJB's biggest water treatment plants.

"During normal days, the water production is around 1,000 MGD, but due to a prolonged dry spell, problems have

increased. The water that we used to draw from Wazirabad has reduced significantly," said the DJB officials.

The Yamuna river at Wazirabad remains critically low at around 668 feet against the required normal of 674.5 feet, which is around five feet below normal, he added.

DJB's overall average production capacity ranges between 990-1,000 MGD of drinking water, including the tubewells. As per current estimates, approximately 70-90 MGD of overall water produc-

tion has been reduced due to problems with low pondage levels at Wazirabad.

Delhi, being a landlocked city, is dependent on the neighbouring states of Haryana and Uttar Pradesh for raw water supply. Currently, two of DJB's water treatment plants -- Wazirabad and Chandrawal -- have been affected the most.

Despite Haryana's assurance of 1,000 cusecs through the Munak Canal, water shortages persist across several Delhi areas, with no improvement timeline announced. **PTI**

Information regarding the collapse of the building in Prakash Vihar near the Delhi-Uttar Pradesh border, was received at Karawal Nagar police station at around 6.30 pm. During a preliminary enquiry, it was found that civil work related to the construction or repair of a nearby drain was being carried out by a civic department of Uttar Pradesh in the adjoining area.

At around 3 pm, cracks appeared in the four-storey building, prompting authorities to immediately evacuate the structure as a precautionary measure, police said.

The building subsequently collapsed, but no one was injured as all occupants had been moved to safety before the incident.

Teams from the Fire Department, the Delhi Disaster Management Authority (DDMA) and other civic agencies rushed to the spot and undertook preventive and safety measures in the area.

Authorities are examining the circumstances that led to the collapse and further enquiry into the matter is underway.

Man fined Rs 26,500 for Thar stunt video

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: Traffic police issued a challan of Rs 26,500 after a video of a man performing stunts with a Thar in Gurugram surfaced online, officials said on Tuesday.

In the video, the man could be seen driving a black Thar at high speed and performing stunts in front of the Lemon Tree Hotel in Sector 60.

Traffic police spokesperson Vikas Kumar said that based on the video, the Thar's registration number was traced, and the challan was issued.

The challan was issued for "dangerous driving, use of black film, driving without a number plate, violation of pollution standards and non-use of a seat belt by the front passenger, etc.," Kumar said.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Capital saw a slight increase in temperature on Wednesday even as the India Meteorological Department (IMD) issued a yellow alert for the next two days, warning of possible rain, thunderstorms and gusty winds.

Safdarjung, representative of the city's weather, recorded a maximum temperature of

39.1 degrees Celsius, 0.9 degree below normal and 1.4 degree more than a day before. The minimum temperature was logged at 27.4 degrees Celsius, 0.5 degree above normal and 0.6 degree more than Tuesday.

Other weather stations also recorded a similar trend of a slight increase in temperature. Palam recorded a 3.7 degree rise in the maximum tempera-

TEMPERATURES RISE SLIGHTLY

Yellow alert for 2 days as IMD forecasts rain, gusty winds



ture, which was logged at 39.6 degree Celsius; Lodhi Road

recorded a maximum temperature of 38.8 degrees Celsius, 2.8 degree more than a day before; Ridge recorded a maximum of 39.3 degrees and Ayanagar recorded a maximum temperature of 39.6 degrees Celsius, a 2.1 degree and 3.5 degree rise from a day before, respectively.

The minimum temperature across weather stations in Delhi also recorded a slight increase. Meanwhile, the IMD

issued a yellow alert for Thursday and Friday.

"Partly to generally cloudy skies are expected to persist for the next two days. A yellow alert has been issued for Thursday and Friday, as light rain is expected, accompanied by thunderstorms, lightning and strong winds of speed reaching 40-50 kmph, even gusting to 60 kmph," said an IMD official.

MONTH-LONG SAFETY AUDIT LAUNCHED ACROSS HOTELS, NURSING HOMES, COACHING CENTRES

Malviya Nagar blaze reignites concerns over fire safety

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Nearly five months after the Delhi High Court directed civic authorities to formulate an action plan to address fire safety lapses in hotels and hospitality establishments, a devastating blaze at a bed-and-breakfast facility in Malviya Nagar has left 21 people dead, triggering a city-wide enforcement drive and fresh scrutiny of Delhi's fire safety regime.

The latest fire broke out on Wednesday morning at Flourish Stay Guest House in Hauz Rani. According to the Delhi Disaster Management Authority (DDMA), information about the blaze was received at 8:52 am, following which emergency agencies were mobilised. Fifteen fire tenders, police teams, DDMA personnel, health officials and CATS ambulances participated in the rescue operation. Authorities said around 30 to 40 people were feared trapped inside the five-storey building. A total of 47 victims were taken to hospitals. Of them, 21 died, 17 sustained injuries and nine remain critical. Preliminary findings indicate the fire originated in a restaurant on the ground floor. The search and rescue operation concluded at 12:12 pm.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta expressed grief over the incident, saying, "Deeply sad-



Police cordon off the area after a fire broke out in a five-storey building in Malviya Nagar, on Wednesday

dened by the tragic loss of lives in the devastating fire incident in Malviya Nagar. My heartfelt condolences to the bereaved families." She added that the Delhi government was extending all possible assistance to affected families.

The incident has gained added significance because of a Delhi High Court order dated January 7. Hearing a PIL filed by petitioner Arpit Bhargava, a bench led by Chief Justice D.K. Upadhyaya had directed the Delhi government, MCD and NDMC to treat the petition as a representation and devise an action plan to prevent fire-related disasters. The court had observed that authorities should "address the issues and devise an action plan to put in

place the safety measures so that fire incidents and other accidents may be avoided."

Bhargava has alleged that no meaningful action followed despite repeated reminders. "There has been no decision whatsoever despite clear directions from the court to prepare an action plan. I had even sent reminders which were not taken into consideration. Complete apathy," he said.

Following the tragedy, Ashish Sood conducted an inspection of the site and ordered an immediate city-wide crackdown on illegal and non-compliant guest houses operating under the Bed & Breakfast scheme. Preliminary investigations revealed alleged violations including unauthorised

commercial expansion, illegal addition of rooms, blocked evacuation routes and operation beyond the permitted six-room capacity. Sood said the government had adopted a "zero-tolerance policy" towards illegal commercial operations that compromise public safety. He directed district authorities, MCD officials, Delhi Fire Services and power distribution agencies to inspect all registered and suspected B&B establishments and take action, including sealing premises, disconnecting utilities and initiating criminal proceedings against violators.

Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu has also ordered a month-long fire safety compliance drive cov-

ering hotels, nursing homes, coaching centres and resorts across the capital.

Meanwhile, Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra blamed previous administrations for allowing illegal hotels to flourish. "The chaotic state of hotels in Delhi today is the result of 27 years of corruption by successive Delhi governments," he alleged, while announcing inspections of hotels, motels and similar establishments across the city. The inspection drive is expected to begin immediately as authorities face mounting pressure to prevent another tragedy.

The tragedy has also revived attention on an underway proposal by Delhi Fire Services (DFS) in May to expand mandatory fire safety clearances. During May, officials had pointed out that nearly 95% of Delhi's buildings are below the 17.5-metre threshold prescribed under the National Building Code, leaving them outside the mandatory fire No Objection Certificate (NOC) framework. Home Minister Ashish Sood had then argued for stricter norms, saying, "The time for a fire to escalate into its fatal nature has reduced as compared to previous years because of the lack of ventilation in houses. Therefore, it should become mandatory for residents to have sensors and sprinklers."

No fire NOCs and poor evacuation routes found at Malviya Ngr hotels

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: Authorities have initiated action against several hotels in South Delhi's Malviya Nagar after inspections carried out in the wake of the recent deadly hotel fire uncovered serious fire safety violations.

According to officials, nearby establishments, including Lemon Green Inn, Micasa Hotel and Hotel Green Residency, were found to be operating without mandatory Fire No Objection Certificates (NOCs).

Inspections also revealed the absence of adequate emergency evacuation arrangements, raising concerns about the safety of guests. Officials said the hotels have only a single entry and exit point and share walls with adjoining buildings, significantly increasing the risk during an emergency.

In the event of a fire, guests would have limited escape options, with windows and rooftops serving as the only possible evacuation routes. Inspecting teams also reportedly found no functional fire extinguishers on the premises.



The lack of basic firefighting equipment and emergency preparedness measures has alarmed authorities, particularly in the aftermath of the recent fire tragedy in the area, which highlighted the consequences of poor safety compliance. The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has issued notices to the hotels and directed them to undergo detailed inspections covering fire safety measures, building approvals and other mandatory clearances.

Officials will examine whether the establish-

ments comply with applicable building and safety regulations before deciding on further action. Guests staying at the affected hotels also expressed concern. A guest at Hotel Green Residency said, "These hotels don't have fire extinguishers or proper ventilation for fresh air and sunlight. They also have only one entry-exit point." Authorities have directed hotel operators to immediately rectify safety deficiencies and comply with regulations to prevent any potential disaster and ensure the safety of guests and staff.

MCD orders high-level probe

Will examine regulatory violations, official lapses...

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has ordered a high-level inquiry into the Malviya Nagar hotel incident, with Mayor Pravesh Wahi directing the MCD Commissioner to submit a detailed report within three days.

According to the Mayor's office, the probe will examine whether the establishment violated building bylaws, fire safety regulations or other statutory provisions. It will also assess whether there were any lapses or negligence on the part of municipal officials and recommend action against those found responsible.

Separately, Standing Committee Chairperson Satya



Sharma visited the site along with MCD Commissioner Sanjeev Khirwar and senior officials. Sharma said a comprehensive inquiry had been ordered to examine the building's age, ownership details,

licensing status and compliance with safety requirements.

She said strict action would be taken against anyone found guilty and announced inspections of other hotels in the area to identify irregularities. "Citizen safety remains our top priority, and negligence will not be tolerated," she said.

Wahi has also directed officials to review safety compliance across commercial establishments, restaurants and other public-use buildings in the city. He urged residents to report violations of safety norms to the authorities.

The move signals a wider enforcement drive, with civic authorities promising stricter scrutiny of safety compliance and greater accountability for violations.

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The fire at the Flourish Stay B&B hotel in South Delhi's Malviya Nagar triggered scenes of panic on Wednesday as guests scrambled to escape the smoke-filled building and local residents rushed in to assist with rescue efforts.

Eyewitnesses said flames and thick smoke spread rapidly through parts of the hotel, leaving many occupants struggling to find a way out. While some managed to flee through staircases and exits, others climbed to the terrace or attempted to escape through windows.

Residents of the area played a crucial role in the initial rescue operation, help-

“Wasim Raja, who also participated in the rescue effort, recounted witnessing a particularly distressing scene, saying a foreigner was burnt to death on the hotel's staircase and was running for her life”

ing evacuate trapped guests before emergency teams completed the evacuation. Several victims were pulled out of the building by locals, who also administered CPR to unconscious occupants in an effort to save lives.

One resident recalled seeing the fire moments after it broke out. "I was just passing by to buy milk when I saw fire on the hotel's ground

floor," he said.

Armaan, who runs a mattress shop near the hotel, said local residents quickly arranged mattresses outside the building to help stranded guests escape.

"We asked them to jump from the windows onto the mattress," he said, describing the desperate attempts to bring people to safety.

Another resident, Shobeb, entered the smoke-filled build-

ing to help those trapped inside. "The smoke was so thick that victims couldn't come out. I had to go inside and take them out," he said.

Wasim Raja, who also participated in the rescue effort, recounted witnessing a particularly distressing scene on the staircase. "A foreigner was burnt to death on the hotel's staircase and was running for her life," he said.

The incident prompted a large-scale emergency response, with firefighters and rescue personnel working for several hours to evacuate occupants and bring the blaze under control.

Authorities have launched an investigation to determine the cause of the fire.

NEW DELHI: Delhi Congress chief Devender Yadav on Wednesday blamed the BJP-led Delhi government and civic agencies for the Malviya Nagar hotel fire, alleging serious lapses in enforcement and oversight. Visiting the site with senior party leaders, Yadav said responsibility lay not only with the operators but also with agencies tasked with ensuring compliance.

He claimed the guest-house was operating beyond its permitted capacity, alleging that while approval had been granted for six rooms, more than 20 were found on the premises. Calling it the fourth major fire incident in Delhi in three months, Yadav accused authorities of failing to act against safety violations. **MP05T**

MCD House leader inspects civic facilities

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Leader of the House in the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), Jai Bhagwan Yadav, on Wednesday inspected civic facilities in Sultan Puri and directed officials to undertake key infrastructure improvements.

During his visit to Ward No. 43, accompanied by local councillor Bobby and senior officials, he reviewed road conditions and ordered expedited repair work.

Yadav directed the renovation of a dilapidated community hall and a municipal school building in C-6 block using CMD funds, noting that students had been shifted elsewhere due to the building's condition. He also ordered restoration of power supply to the local Malaria Office and improvements to a park.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has initiated preparations for the 8th Economic Census, a large-scale exercise aimed at creating a comprehensive database of business establishments, trade units and entrepreneurial activities operating across the national capital. According to officials, the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation has designated the Directorate of Economics and Statistics of the Delhi government as the nodal agency for conducting the census in the city. An order issued by the Planning Department on Monday stated that all 13 district administrations will function as sub-agencies and assist in implementing the exercise.

As part of the preparations, statistical officers and statis-

HIGHLIGHTS

» As part of the preps, statistical officers and statistical assistants posted in dist offices under the Revenue Dep have been

directed to coordinate census-related activities assigned by Directorate

» These personnel will carry out the work in accordance with guidelines issued by the Centre

tical assistants posted in district offices under the Revenue Department have been directed to coordinate census-related activities assigned by the Directorate. Officials said these personnel will carry out the work in accordance with guidelines issued by the Centre while continuing to perform their regular responsibilities.

The economic census is expected to be undertaken after the completion of the ongoing population census exercise, which is scheduled to conclude in early 2027. Authorities said

the economic census will follow soon after and will focus on collecting detailed information about economic establishments operating in Delhi.

The exercise will document key aspects of entrepreneurial and business units, including their location, type of activity, operational characteristics and sources of finance. The data collected is expected to provide a clearer picture of Delhi's economic landscape and support evidence-based policymaking.

Officials said the information generated through the

census will serve as a foundation for future socio-economic surveys and help governments design targeted schemes and sector-specific development programmes. The findings are also expected to aid planning related to employment generation, business growth and infrastructure development.

A large workforce will be deployed for the exercise. Enumerators, teachers from the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) and New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC), along with other government employees, are likely to be engaged in data collection and field verification work.

The Economic Census is conducted periodically across the country to capture the scale and nature of economic activities and provide reliable data for development planning and resource allocation.

Delhi Medical Council gets new governing panel

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Medical Council (DMC) has elected a new eight-member governing council following polls held on May 31 at its Shastrri Park office. Registered medical practitioners voted to elect members of the statutory body that regulates the practice of modern medicine in the national capital.

The newly elected council comprises Dr Prakash Lalchandani, Dr Manjusha Goel, Dr Ajay Bedi, Dr Piyush Jain, Dr Rakesh Kumar Gupta, Dr Ashok Kumar Grover, Dr Ashwini Dalmia and Dr Vipender Sabherwal. Lalchandani secured the highest number of votes with 2,481. The elections were held amid allegations by some members of the medical fraternity regarding irregularities in the electoral process.

CM Gupta hears public grievances and orders prompt action by depts



AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday interacted directly with citizens during a public hearing programme at the Jan Seva Sadan, directing officials to ensure swift resolution of complaints and pending cases raised by residents from across the capital.

A large number of people approached the Chief Minister with issues related to civic services, education, social welfare, revenue, policing and other administrative matters. During the hearing, Gupta sought detailed reports from concerned departments and instructed officials to take prompt action wherever required.

Among the cases discussed was a civic grievance related to the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, on which the Chief Minister directed authorities to review pending matters on priority and provide appropriate solutions. In another case, a woman highlighted difficulties affecting her children's education, prompting Gupta to order immediate assistance from the concerned officials.

She also took note of a complaint involving banking-related issues and a family dispute. Officials were directed to provide necessary legal and administrative support to ensure a fair resolution of the matter.

Addressing officials, the Chief Minister stressed the importance of responsiveness in governance and asked departments to give priority attention to public complaints.

"The government's objective is not merely to formulate schemes, but to ensure that the benefits of governance effectively reach every citizen," Gupta said.

Emphasising the government's commitment to inclusive governance, she added, "We are working in the spirit of Antyodaya so that relief, facilities and justice reach even the last person standing in society."

The Chief Minister said public hearings not only help resolve individual grievances but also provide valuable feedback for improving administrative functioning and strengthening accountability between the government and citizens.

Foundation laid for Rs 47.26 crore projects in Bawana

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Cabinet Minister and Bawana MLA Ravinder Indraj Singh on Wednesday laid the foundation stone for development projects worth Rs.47.26 crore in the Bawana Assembly constituency, aimed at strengthening infrastructure, improving civic amenities and accelerating planned urban-rural growth in the area.

PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh attended the programme as the chief guest.



The projects launched include the Kanjhawala Road Drain Project, stretching from Punjab Sweets to the Rohini Sector 21/22 dividing road, and the Rural Redevelopment Project for Rohini Sectors 20 and 21. According to officials, the initiatives are expected to improve drainage infrastruc-

“Projects include the Kanjhawala Road Drain Project and the Rural Redevelopment Project for Rohini Sectors 20 and 21”

ture, enhance public facilities and support balanced development across the constituency.

Addressing residents, Ravinder Indraj Singh said Bawana remains a key part of Delhi's rural belt and is receiving priority attention from the government. "Under the leadership of the double-engine

government, Bawana is rapidly setting new benchmarks of development," he said.

The minister also announced that additional development projects worth nearly Rs.60 crore would soon be launched in the constituency.

"The pace of development

in Bawana Assembly Constituency and Delhi's rural areas is now unstoppable.

"Our government is committed to providing permanent solutions to long-pending issues of the region," Singh said. He added that sustained efforts would help transform Bawana into a modern, well-planned and prosperous constituency in the coming years.

Highlighting the government's broader development agenda, Singh said infrastructure expansion, public welfare

and rural upliftment remain key priorities under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta.

A large number of local residents, community representatives, social workers and BJP workers attended the event and welcomed the projects.

Residents expressed hope that the new initiatives would improve connectivity, drainage and civic infrastructure while addressing long-standing development needs in the area.

Checked in, never checked out: 21 killed in hotel inferno

Continued from Page 1

Firefighting units and senior fire officers.

By 9:45 am, fire officials reported that three persons had been rescued from the basement by DFS personnel and rushed to the hospital by CATS ambulances.

Simultaneously, local police, fire personnel, disaster management teams, and ambulance services launched a large-scale rescue operation in the densely packed Hauz Rani area.

Police said more than 40 people were rescued and shifted to nearby hospitals for treatment. However, despite the extensive rescue efforts, 21 people succumbed to their injuries, many of them due to smoke inhalation and asphyxiation.

Eyewitnesses described scenes of panic and horror as guests attempted to flee the burning building. Several survivors reportedly jumped from upper floors after being trapped by smoke-filled corridors.

The narrow lanes surrounding the hotel complex posed additional challenges for emergency responders, though authorities said rescue teams reached the site promptly and prevented an even greater catastrophe.

Medical teams treating the injured revealed that smoke inhalation was the primary

cause of casualties. Dr. Sandeep Budhiraja, Medical Director of Max Healthcare Group, said, "Eight patients are on ventilators and undergoing treatment. The majority of them have suffered from asphyxiation injuries caused by smoke inhalation. Most have minor burns while one patient with more than 25 per cent burns has been shifted to Safdarjung Hospital."

He added that many victims sustained fractures after jumping from the building. "Patients have suffered lung injuries, minor burns, and bone injuries. Several people claimed they jumped from high floors. We have cases of long bone fractures, pelvic fractures, and one spinal injury requiring neurosurgery."

Hospital authorities confirmed that foreign nationals were among both the deceased and the injured. Officials said 12 of the 21 victims were citizens of Afghanistan, African nations, Turkmenistan, and Nigeria.

The tragedy has triggered allegations of widespread violations by the hotel's operators. Local residents claimed that Flourish Stay B&B lacked a mandatory fire No Objection Certificate (NOC) and was operating far beyond its approved capacity.

According to government officials, the four-storey Flourish Stay B&B in Delhi's Malviya

Nagar is operating far beyond its permitted capacity, with nearly 25 rooms despite having approval for only six. Residents further alleged that several nearby hotels, including Lemon Green Inn, Micasa Hotel, and Hotel Green Residency, were also operating without valid fire clearances and lacked adequate emergency exits and firefighting equipment.

Locals accused civic authorities of failing to conduct proper inspections despite repeated concerns about safety violations in the area.

The spotlight has also fallen on hotel owner Lovkesh Bajaj, who allegedly owns multiple hospitality properties across Delhi.

Residents claimed several of these establishments lacked proper fire safety measures and emergency evacuation routes. Authorities said efforts were underway to locate Bajaj, who is reportedly absconding.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi expressed grief over the tragedy, stating, "My condolences to those who have lost their loved ones. Wishing a speedy recovery to the injured. Authorities are providing all possible assistance to those affected."

The Prime Minister's Office announced an ex gratia of 2 lakh rupees from the Prime Minister's National Relief Fund for the next of kin of each deceased vic-

tim and 50,000 rupees for those injured.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta also expressed condolences, saying, "Deeply saddened by the tragic loss of lives in the devastating fire incident in Malviya Nagar. My heartfelt condolences to the bereaved families. I pray for the speedy recovery of those injured and for strength and courage to all those affected."

She said the Delhi government was closely monitoring the situation and ensuring all medical assistance and support for affected families.

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu said he was "deeply distressed" by the incident and had directed officials to ensure immediate medical aid, relief measures and a thorough investigation into the cause of the fire.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah described the incident as heartbreaking and extended condolences to the families of those killed while wishing a speedy recovery to the injured.

The rescue operation also left several police personnel injured while entering smoke-filled sections of the building. Ten police officers and personnel, including head constables and constables from Malviya Nagar, Neb Sarai and PCR units, were admitted to AIIMS Trauma Centre after

exposure to hazardous conditions. Officials said all were stable and under observation.

Delhi Minister Ashish Sood announced strict enforcement measures in the wake of the tragedy.

"Permission had been granted in 2024 to operate a six-room bed-and-breakfast establishment. Following today's tragic incident, we have decided to conduct a thorough investigation and seal all such buildings that do not have the requisite NOCs and approvals. Permissions of establishments found violating norms will be cancelled," he said.

Meanwhile, Delhi Municipal Corporation Chairperson Satya Sharma visited the site along with the MCD Commissioner and ordered an inquiry into the incident.

As rescue teams continued combing through the debris and investigators began examining the cause of the fire, the Malviya Nagar tragedy has emerged as a grim reminder of the deadly consequences of ignoring fire safety regulations.

With allegations of illegal construction, missing clearances, and overcrowding now under scrutiny, the disaster is expected to trigger one of the most extensive investigations into hotel safety compliance in Delhi in recent years.

Cabinet okays Rs 9,585-cr scheme to replace polluting vehicles

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Union Cabinet, chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, has approved a two-year scheme aimed at reducing air pollution in the Delhi-NCR region by accelerating the replacement of older, high-emission trucks and buses with cleaner vehicles.

With a total cost of Rs 9,585 crore, the plan draws Rs 5,041 crore from central funds alongside approximately Rs 1,601 crore in state-level tax relief across involved regions.

Funding flows via the National Capital Region Planning Board, operating under the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs. Execution rests with the Ministries of Road Transport and Highways and Petroleum and Natural Gas, working jointly with Delhi, Haryana, Rajasthan, and Uttar Pradesh.

Implementation unfolds through coordinated efforts among these regional and national bodies.

About 2.07 lakh vehicle owners fall under the scope - 1.91 lakh truck holders and

Highlights

» With a total cost of Rs 9,585 crore, the plan draws Rs 5,041 crore from central funds alongside approximately Rs 1,601 crore in state-level tax relief across involved regions

» About 2.07 lakh vehicle owners fall under the scope - 1.91 lakh truck holders and 1,32,9 bus operators across Delhi-NCR

» For those holding BS-III or older units, dismantling at authorised centres is required

16,329 bus operators across Delhi-NCR. Replacement of BS-IV or earlier models with BS-VI or electric alternatives becomes a focus.

For those holding BS-III or older units, dismantling at authorised centres is required. Meanwhile, BS-IV category vehicles face two paths: decommissioning or transfer beyond NCR into areas without NCAP enforcement.

Five years of support include a 5 per cent interest reduction on vehicle financing, offered by the Centre. Fuel assistance arrives each month, reaching as much as Rs 4,800 in value. Purchasers choosing electric models gain further benefits beyond standard terms.

Waived registration charges appear under state-level measures.

Tax reductions apply through regional policies on motor vehicles. Outstanding dues tied to older transport units get settled early. Additional encouragement emerges where both levels of government align incentives.

A system operated via online platform ensures smooth execution, oversight resting with a committee led by the Cabinet Secretary. Progress unfolds under structured review, accountability built into each phase. Emission levels in Delhi-NCR are projected to decline, air conditions expected to shift gradually.

From Page 1

US trade salvo

selected economies to enter the US at lower tariff rates.

The 12.5 per cent duty has been proposed on 54 countries including Argentina, Australia, Bangladesh, Brazil, Cambodia, China, India, Israel, Japan, Malaysia, New Zealand, Norway, Oman, Philippines, Qatar, Russia, Saudi Arabia, Singapore, South Africa, South Korea, Sri Lanka, Switzerland, Thailand, the UAE, the UK, and Vietnam.

A 10 per cent additional import duty has been proposed on six nations - Canada, Ecuador, the European Union, Indonesia, Mexico, and Pakistan.

The USTR statement said that it has determined that the acts, policies, and practices of these 60 economies related to the failure to impose and effectively enforce a prohibition on the importation of goods produced with forced labour are unreasonable and burden or restrict US commerce, and are thus actionable under the provision.

"The failure of our most important trading partners to address the importation of goods made with forced labour is unacceptable. This creates a dynamic where American workers are forced to compete globally on an unlevel playing field," US Trade Representative Ambassador Jamieson Greer said in a statement.

"We will no longer tolerate this disparity," he said.

The USTR proposal comes amid the three-day talks underway in Delhi to finalise the first tranche of the bilateral trade agreement (BTA) between the two countries. The US team is led by its chief negotiator Brendan Lynch. India's chief negotiator is Darpan Jain, Additional Secretary, Department of Commerce.

On February 7, India and the US issued a joint statement finalising the contours or framework of the first phase of the BTA or an interim trade deal.

According to the framework, the US agreed to reduce tariffs on India to 18 per cent from 50 per cent. It removed the 25 per cent tariffs on Indian goods for buying Russian oil and was to cut the remaining 25 per cent to 18 per cent under the pact.

But, on February 20 this year, the US Supreme Court ruled against President Donald Trump's sweeping reciprocal tariffs, which were imposed under the 1977 International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA).

Following that, the US President announced the imposition of 10 per cent tariffs on all countries for 150 days, starting February 24. As the US Supreme Court has ruled against President Donald Trump's sweeping tariffs, the US administration now has the option of using the Section 301 investigation mechanism to impose new tariffs.

The US was the second-largest trading partner of India in 2025-26. India's outbound shipments to

the US grew marginally 0.92 per cent to USD 87.3 billion during the last fiscal year, while imports increased 15.95 per cent to USD 52.9 billion. The trade surplus declined to USD 34.4 billion in 2025-26 from USD 40.89 billion in 2024-25.

Ritabrata

58 legislators before Speaker Rathindra Bose, crossing the two-thirds threshold required under the anti-defection law for recognition as a separate bloc.

Several veteran TMC legislators joined the rebellion, including Samar Mukhopadhyay, Arup Roy, Rathin Ghosh, Javed Khan and Prasun Banerjee.

"Our claim has been accepted by the Speaker," Ritabrata told reporters after meeting the Speaker.

Ritabrata, a former blue-eyed boy of the Left Front, was expelled from CPI(M) in 2017 for anti-party activities and later joined the TMC.

Claiming legitimacy through numbers, he asserted that the dissidents now represented the real TMC in the Assembly.

"The TMC legislative party is a team of 58 MLAs who won on the TMC symbol. We are the real TMC now in the Assembly," he said.

The dissident camp unveiled a new leadership structure, naming Ritabrata Banerjee as LoP and Akhruzzaman as chief whip. Senior legislators and party old-timers Javed Ahmed Khan, Sandipan Saha, Sabina Yasmin and Shiuli Saha were appointed deputy leaders.

Speaking to the media, Ritabrata claimed that two more TMC MLAs were set to join his camp, which would take the strength of the rebel faction to 60 legislators. Confident of commanding a clear majority within the legislature party, he said he could not comment on the future role of the remaining 20 MLAs, who are believed to continue backing Mamata Banerjee. TMC had won 80 seats in the 2026 Assembly polls.

This has escalated an internal crisis that has exposed deep divisions within the party following its electoral setback and raised questions over the authority of the existing leadership.

Interestingly, in their communication to the Speaker, they continued to recognise Mamata Banerjee as chairperson of the Trinamool Congress while making it equally clear that they no longer accepted the authority of party national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee in the functioning of the legislature party. "We accept Mamata Banerjee as our leader but do not accept Abhishek Banerjee," a leader associated with the dissident camp reportedly said.

"We would request Mamata Banerjee to play the role of the chief adviser of the legislative party," Ritabrata said.

However, the Mamata Banerjee camp questioned the validity of the rebels' move, claiming that the communication to the Speaker was submitted on plain paper rather than the party's official letterhead. It maintained that only the party chairperson

and national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee were empowered to convey such decisions to the Assembly.

The situation within TMC has drawn comparisons with the 2022 rebellion in the Shiv Sena, when more than 40 legislators led by Eknath Shinde broke away from Uddhav Thackeray. The unified Shiv Sena had 55 MLAs back then. Ritabrata is being referred to as Bengal's Eknath Shinde after he led the TMC rebellion.

The split, triggered by allegations that a proposal submitted to the Speaker seeking recognition of senior TMC MLA Sobhandeb Chattopadhyay contained forged signatures of several legislators, has plunged the party into uncharted territory. The controversy led to the filing of an FIR and a CID investigation, eventually snowballing into a full-blown rebellion within the party.

Ritabrata and Sandipan Saha had raised concerns over the signatures on an earlier letter submitted to the Speaker in support of Chattopadhyay's candidature for the LoP post. The party, acting swiftly, expelled both the leaders.

The developments have now raised crucial questions over Mamata Banerjee's next move and which faction will ultimately gain control of the party symbol. Whether the TMC supremo opts for legal recourse to stem further defections and challenge the new power equations remains to be seen.

Amid the deepening crisis, Mamata convened a crucial meeting at her Kalighat residence on Wednesday evening to chart the party's next course of action. Only a handful of MLAs loyal to her camp attended the meeting, which was also attended by senior leaders Firhad Hakim, Kunal Ghosh and Sobhandeb Chattopadhyay.

Meanwhile, TMC MLA Kunal Ghosh said the differences could have been settled within the party and accused the dissident group of "backstabbing" the organisation during a challenging period.

A section of TMC leaders backing Mamata Banerjee alleged that several MLAs in the rebel camp may have switched sides out of fear of facing various investigations. They pointed to the BJP's earlier claims that the TMC would eventually disintegrate, suggesting that the developments could be linked to political pressure, fear and concerns over possible probes.

Dissolving all party committees, TMC said it will undertake "comprehensive introspection, performance review" and all the frontal wings will be "reconstructed".

In a post on X, TMC said: "The party will undertake a comprehensive exercise of introspection, performance review and organisational assessment at every level. Based on the findings of this exercise, the organisational structure of the parent body and all frontal organisations will be reconstituted and announced in due course."

"After careful consideration, it has been decided that all committees of the All India Trinamool Congress in West Bengal, as well as all its frontal organisations, shall stand dissolved with immediate effect," TMC added in its social media post. "Based

on the findings of this exercise, the organisational structure of the parent body and all frontal organisations will be reconstituted and announced in due course," the statement further added. The party did not elaborate on the reasons behind the decision.

Reacting to the developments, BJP MLA Tapas Roy said: "There is growing dissatisfaction among many TMC leaders and legislators. The developments indicate that the party is heading towards a split, similar to what happened in Maharashtra."

The political beneficiary, many observers argue, is Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari, himself once one of Mamata Banerjee's closest lieutenants before crossing over to the BJP and emerging as her fiercest rival.

The crisis also carries a layer of political irony that has not gone unnoticed by the Opposition.

Both the CPI(M) and Congress said the TMC was now experiencing the same politics of defections that it had perfected after coming to power in 2011.

Annapurna Yojana funds

Dinaipur (49,327), Darjeeling (41,031), Kolkata (23,807) and Kalimpong (9,675).

Adhikari symbolically handed over benefits to five beneficiaries from Howrah district — Sumitra Roy, Sandhya Bhaduri, Rajkumari Devi, Rinku Porel and Sumi Mandi.

The Chief Minister said the government had initially considered implementing the scheme without a formal application process. However, verification exercises revealed that several individuals whose names had been removed from electoral rolls during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) were still receiving benefits under welfare schemes introduced by the previous administration, including Lakshmir Bhandar.

Alleging that funds had been deposited into thousands of fraudulent accounts, Adhikari said a detailed application process was necessary. He clarified that 1.21 lakh women who have applied under the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA), as well as those who have approached tribunals after exclusion from voter lists, would receive benefits under the scheme.

State Women and Child Development Minister Agnimitra Paul said failure to complete the 12-page application form would not automatically disqualify applicants. The information was being collected as the government plans additional welfare programmes and to ensure that only Indian citizens receive benefits.

Adhikari said citizens facing difficulties in availing government schemes could call the helpline between 9 am and 6 pm from Monday to Saturday or email asap@wb.gov.in.

The Apnar Sorkar Apnar Pashe initiative replaces Sarasari Mukhyamantri, launched by the previous Trinamool Congress government in June 2023. Before that, the ruling party had launched Didi Ke Bolo.

Both initiatives later became

controversial amid allegations that the phone numbers used for the programmes were linked to political consultancy firm I-PAC, then associated with the Trinamool Congress. Critics alleged that complaints and personal information were routed through systems operated by the consultancy, while many citizens later complained that the helpline numbers had become inaccessible.

The portfolios of the 35 ministers who took oath at Lok Bhavan on Monday are scheduled to be announced on June 5.

Kuwait Airport

"We extend our sincere condolences and sympathies to the family of the deceased and his relatives, and we wish a speedy recovery to all the injured," said Colonel Saud Abdulaziz Al-Otaibi, the official spokesman of the Ministry of Defence.

Earlier, an Indian national was killed in Kuwait in Iranian strikes on a power and water desalination plant on March 30.

Kuwaiti Interior Ministry spokesperson Brigadier General Nasser Bousleeb said that the passenger terminal (T1) at the airport was subjected to an attack by several hostile drones.

Kuwait suspended air traffic on Wednesday after the Iranian strikes hit Terminal 1, causing casualties and damage to airport facilities, Directorate General of Civil Aviation spokesperson Abdullah Al-Rajhi was quoted as saying by the state-run KUNA news agency.

Air traffic was suspended and flights were diverted to nearby airports until further notice, he said.

The Kuwaiti foreign ministry later summoned the Charge d'Affaires at the Iranian Embassy and handed him an official protest note regarding the attacks.

Two members of the Iranian diplomatic mission have been declared persona non grata and asked to leave Kuwaiti territory within 24 hours, KUNA reported.

Last month, an Indian sailor was killed and several others injured after their wooden dhow caught fire near the Strait of Hormuz.

Later, Kuwaiti civil aviation authorities said the country's main airport has partially reopened Wednesday after an Iranian attack damaged it.

Kuwait Airways flights resumed from a different terminal from the one that was hit. No other flights would be operating, they said.

Meanwhile, India strongly condemned the attack on Kuwait International Airport that killed an Indian citizen and injured many others, even as it called for protecting civilians and civilian installations amid ongoing conflicts in West Asia.

"The government strongly condemns the attack on the Kuwait International Airport today in which one Indian national has died, and several of our nationals have been injured," the MEA said in a statement.

MEA highlighted, "It is deeply regretted that in West Asia, since the outbreak of hostilities, there has always been an insistence that the civilian population and infrastructure should not be attacked.

We urge once more to stop such attacks."

The ministry also offered condolences to the deceased's family while ensuring its support for the victims. "Our heartfelt sympathies go out to the bereaved family. The Embassy will do everything in its capacity to assist the injured victims. We are in constant touch with the local authorities to help our citizens," the statement concluded.

The MEA further noted that Indian Missions and Posts across the region remain on alert and are continuing to provide proactive support to the Indian community.

In a post on the social media platform X, the Indian Embassy in Kuwait said it was "closely coordinating" with Kuwaiti authorities to assist the bereaved family and those injured in the attack.

"Embassy of India in Kuwait expresses its deepest condolences at the tragic demise of an Indian national due to an attack on the airport in Kuwait today. The Embassy is in touch with the bereaved family and is closely coordinating with the Kuwaiti authorities to render all possible support and assistance to the bereaved family as well as those injured in the incident," the mission said.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

DK takes

the oath in the name of the revered seer "Gangadhar Ajja" while holding a copy of the Constitution. He bowed, and paid obeisance to the gathering before taking the oath.

Senior Dalit MLA G Parameshwara, who will be the new Deputy CM, took oath in the name of Dr B R Ambedkar.

Along with Shivakumar and Parameshwara, the legislators, who took oath as Ministers are -- K H Muniyappa, K J George, M B Patil, Ramalinga Reddy, Satish Jarkiholi, Krishna Byregowda, Priyank Kharage, U T Khader, Eshwar Khadre, Yathindra Siddaramaiah, Byrathi Suresh, and Sharan Prakash Patil.

Eleven of the 13 ministers inducted into Shivakumar-led cabinet were part of the previous Siddaramaiah government in the state. Interestingly, Siddaramaiah's son and MLC Yathindra also made it to the Ministry. However, no women representatives were included in the first phase of cabinet formation. Yathindra and U T Khader, who resigned as Legislative Assembly Speaker, are the only two new faces in Shivakumar's cabinet, the rest were part of Siddaramaiah's ministry.

After taking oath, Shivakumar prostrated on the steps of the iconic Vidhana Soudha, the seat of the Karnataka Legislature and Secretariat, before formally assuming charge of his office.

After taking oath, he bowed and touched the steps in reverence, and later paid tributes to national leaders and prominent Karnataka icons as he entered the imposing building for the first time as the chief minister of the state. He asserted that he is deeply conscious that the CM post is far more than a constitutional office, it is a sacred trust placed in him by the people of the state.

By assuming the state's highest political office, the eight-time

MLA Shivakumar, popularly called "DK Shi", has fulfilled his long-cherished dream after a prolonged power tussle with Siddaramaiah.

The 64-year-old Vokkaliga strongman was elected leader of the Congress Legislature Party in Karnataka on May 30, following Siddaramaiah's resignation as CM on May 28. Shivakumar had served as Deputy Chief Minister under Siddaramaiah.

Ahead of swearing-in Shivakumar met outgoing CM Siddaramaiah, veteran BJP leader B S Yediyurappa, and former Prime Minister H D Deve Gowda at their residence.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi congratulated Shivakumar and said the Centre will work closely with the state government for the welfare of the people.

Siddaramaiah, AICC general secretaries K C Venugopal and Randeep Singh Surjewala, CMs of Congress ruled states, several top Congress leaders, dignitaries, and invitees were present at the swearing-in.

Religious leaders from all major communities, including heads of various maths, were also present.

Congratulating Shivakumar and the Ministers, Rahul Gandhi said people's trust in the Congress remains its greatest responsibility. The guarantees of Congress remain the foundations for governance and commitment to social justice, he said, assuring people that they will deliver.

Party sources said more legislators are likely to be inducted in the days to come. Karnataka has a sanctioned strength of 34 ministers, including the chief minister.

A Congress leader said, "While looking at this new cabinet, it may appear that Siddaramaiah's print is clear on it. However, this may also mean that many fresh faces may be inducted in the next phase of cabinet formation."

In terms of caste composition, the cabinet balances representation with three Ministers each from the politically dominant Vokkaliga (including Shivakumar and Ramalinga Reddy) and Veerashaiva-Lingayat communities, and there is an equal number of Dalit Ministers.

While there are two Ministers from the Kuruba community, to which Siddaramaiah belongs; one Minister each are from ST, Christian and Muslim communities.

Looking at district wise representation, the highest number of four Ministers are from Bengaluru Urban, two from Kalaburagi, and one each from Bengaluru South, Bengaluru Rural, Tumakuru, Vijayapura, Bidar, Dakshina Kannada, Belagavi, and Mysuru districts. Yathindra Siddaramaiah is the only MLC to make it to the Ministry, rest all are MLAs.

Sourav Ganguly

Under the 'Z' category security cover, the protectee is covered by 30-35 police personnel, including a few commandos.

The protectee under the 'Z' category is also provided with a pilot vehicle. In contrast, a person covered under the 'Y' category receives security from 3-4 personnel, including two armed guards, but is not entitled to a pilot car.

HAS PLENTY TO FIX BEFORE THE 2028 POLLS

Challenges galore as CM Shivakumar prepares Congress for 2028 battle

OUR CORRESPONDENT

BENGALURU: Having assumed charge as Karnataka's Chief Minister, DK Shivakumar has his task cut out, as he will have to prepare the Congress party for the 2028 Assembly polls in two years, while carefully navigating challenges on multiple fronts.

The 64-year-old leader is helping the government at a crucial phase, as the state faces challenges on political, financial, and administrative fronts.

The first challenge the new chief minister has to carefully address is cabinet formation and portfolio allocation. The CM successfully inducted 13 ministers into his Cabinet in the first phase on Wednesday. Karnataka has a sanctioned strength of 34 ministers, including the chief minister.

With many ministerial aspirants and limited berths available, Shivakumar has a



DK Shivakumar during the swearing-in ceremony PTI

tightrope to walk. In the new Cabinet, he will have to strike a balance by ensuring representation while keeping caste equations, regions, and Siddaramaiah loyalists in mind.

Keeping the AHINDA vote bank with Congress will be one of the key tasks for the Vokkaliga strongman Shivakumar, now that Siddaramaiah has stepped down as chief minister.

The strong consolidation of AHINDA (Kannada acronym for minorities, backward classes and Dalits) votes in favour of Congress, with Siddaramaiah considered a strong proponent of these communities' at the helm, helped Congress come to power in 2023. Their support remains crucial for the party in future polls.

To manage this, Shiva-

Highlights

- » The 64-year-old leader is helping the government at a crucial phase, as the state faces challenges on political, financial, and administrative fronts
- » The first challenge the new chief minister has to carefully address is cabinet formation and portfolio allocation

kumar must work by taking Siddaramaiah and his supporters into confidence while also continuing to remain on good terms with dominant communities.

Shivakumar must also ensure that the other numerically large dominant community in the state, the Veerashiva-Lingayats' spread over large parts of north Kar-

nataka and in some pockets of the south' are not antagonised by any of his decisions.

The test of how Shivakumar will manage various communities will come when the report on the social and educational survey, popularly known as the "caste census," is out.

Various communities, especially the dominant Lingayats and Vokkaligas had strong objections to the earlier survey report and Shivakumar himself had expressed reservations.

Many in Congress believe that Shivakumar's elevation may further consolidate Vokkaligas, who are predominantly present in the old Mysuru region, toward the party, ahead of the 2028 Assembly polls.

The perceptible shift in Vokkaligas' support to Congress in the 2023 Assembly elections was largely prompted by the expectation that Shivakumar would be made the chief minister.

‘Nepal a priority partner’, PM Modi assures RSP chief

Modi, Lamichhane discuss stronger bilateral partnership

OUR CORRESPONDENT



PM Narendra Modi during a meeting with Nepal's RSP chief Rabi Lamichhane PTI

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday reiterated that Nepal remains a key partner for India under its 'Neighbourhood First' policy as he met Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP) chairman Rabi Lamichhane in New Delhi.

The meeting comes amid renewed political activity in Nepal following the formation of a new government, with India signalling its intent to further deepen bilateral ties with the Himalayan nation.

In a post on X after the meeting, Modi said he was "delighted" to meet Lamichhane and welcomed his commitment to strengthening cooperation between the two countries.

"I welcome and fully share his desire to work closely together for a shared and prosperous future. Nepal is a priority partner under our Neighbourhood First policy and we look forward to collaborating with the new government to elevate the special and multi-

faceted relationship between our two countries to greater heights," the prime minister said.

Lamichhane, one of Nepal's prominent political figures and the face of the relatively new Rastriya Swatantra Party, is leading a party delegation on a multi-day visit to India. The delegation arrived in New Delhi on Monday afternoon following an invitation from Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader Nitin Nabin.

The visit is being viewed as significant amid evolving political dynamics in Nepal and growing regional engagement

by India. Relations between the two neighbours are rooted in deep historical, cultural and people-to-people ties, besides strong economic and strategic cooperation.

Over the years, India and Nepal have worked closely in sectors such as connectivity, energy, trade and infrastructure. Several cross-border rail and road connectivity projects, along with power transmission initiatives, have gained momentum in recent years, reflecting both countries' focus on strengthening regional integration.

‘Shamelessly digging heels in’: Cong asks who is shielding Pradhan

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Wednesday launched a scathing attack on Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the CBSE OSM row, saying the Mantri Pradhan is "shamelessly digging" his heels in office and asked why Prime Minister Narendra Modi is insistent on protecting him despite evidence of his ministry's "incompetence and corruption".

Congress leader Jairam Ramesh alleged that the "Mantri Pradhan" runs a "corrupt, incompetent, and callous" Ministry of Education.

"The CBSE leadership may have been transferred out, but the Mantri Pradhan is shamelessly digging his heels in office

Jairam Ramesh alleged that the "Mantri Pradhan" runs a "corrupt, incompetent, and callous" Ministry of Education

Digvijaya Singh-led Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education after it heard from 18-year-old student Sarthak Sidhant, who had first flagged the corruption in the tender via social media," Ramesh said.

This is a glaring lack of accountability at the highest level of the CBSE and Education Ministry, he alleged.

Citing an investigation by an English daily into the CBSE's dry run for its OSM system, Ramesh said it has revealed that several participants in the dry run red-flagged the system and requested that the CBSE delay its adoption until the glitches are resolved and training is provided to all evaluators.

Karnataka mandate big responsibility: Rahul

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday congratulated Chief Minister DK Shivakumar and the new council of ministers in Karnataka, saying people's trust in the Congress remains its greatest responsibility.

The guarantees of Congress remain the foundations for governance and commitment to social justice, he said, assuring people that they will deliver.

Gandhi also thanked former chief minister Siddaramaiah for his leadership and service, which "strengthened Karnataka and improved millions of lives".

"The people of Karnataka placed their trust in us, and that trust remains our great responsibility. Warm congratulations to CM Shri D K Shivakumar ji and the Coun-



Rahul Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge being welcomed by DK Shivakumar PTI

cil of Ministers, who will carry forward the aspirations of the people of Karnataka.

"My sincere thanks to Shri Siddaramaiah ji, whose leadership and service have strengthened Karnataka and improved millions of lives," Gandhi said in a post on X.

"We will keep listening,

delivering and serving the people of Karnataka," the leader of opposition in the Lok Sabha said. State Congress president Shivakumar on Wednesday took oath as the chief minister of Karnataka, along with 13 other legislators sworn in as ministers in his Cabinet, including senior leader G

Parameshwara.

In the presence of Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, Rahul Gandhi and outgoing chief minister Siddaramaiah, Shivakumar took oath in the name of seer 'Gangadhar Ajja', holding a copy of the Constitution in his hand.

Governor Thaawarchand Gehlot administered the oath of office and secrecy to Shivakumar, Parameshwara and others at the Lok Bhavan in Bengaluru. Parameshwara, who is set to be designated as deputy chief minister, took oath in the name of B R Ambedkar.

The other legislators who took oath as ministers included KH Muniyappa, KJ George, M B Patil, Ramalinga Reddy, Satish Jarkiholi, Krishna Byregowda, Priyank Kharge, UT Khader among others.

TVK allocates lone RS seat to Congress

CHENNAI: TVK chief C Joseph Vijay on Wednesday announced that his party would allocate the lone Rajya Sabha seat to Congress that felt vacant after AIADMK leader C Ve Shanmugam resigned from the Upper House.

Shanmugam quit the seat following his victory from the Mailam assembly constituency in the April 23 Assembly election.

"As Rajya Sabha election is to be held in Tamil Nadu on 18th of this month, a seat has been allocated to the All India Congress party, which is part of the alliance led by TVK in Tamil Nadu," Vijay said in a statement.

The TVK's decision to offer the lone Rajya Sabha seat to the Congress came against the backdrop of key meetings between national party leaders, including former union finance minister P Chidambaram and Congress Tamil Nadu in-charge Girish Chodankar at the Secretariat.

After meeting Chief Minister Vijay at his office, Chodankar told reporters that the Congress' presence will be strengthened in the Upper House by getting the Rajya Sabha seat from Tamil Nadu.

Since TVK is the single largest party in the state Assembly, its alliance partner Congress is expected to comfortably win the Rajya Sabha seat.

Election Commission sources said that the nominations began on June 1 and will go on till June 8. The scrutiny of nominations would take place on June 9. The last date of withdrawal will be on June 11.

Annamalai rumours rattle BJP cadres

CHENNAI: Amidst the buzz of former state chief K Annamalai quitting the BJP, cadres from the party, particularly the Yuva Morcha members, on Wednesday demanded the party high command officially clarify the position and avert confusion and possible exodus from the BJP.

Backing the former state president's stance on charting his own political course outside the BJP, Annamalai's supporters put up posters in Madurai showing the former president holding hands with actors Rajinikanth and Ajith.

"After rumours surrounding the exit of Annamalai, the BJP appears to be facing confusion among cadres and supporters. Many are concerned, and some are even considering distancing themselves from the party," BJP Yuva Morcha state secretary R Yogesh said. The party leadership should take swift steps to reassure the cadres at this crucial juncture, he said.

"As state president, Nainar Nagenthiran should address our workers through a video message or an official letter, clarifying the situation and boosting the morale of party workers," Yogesh said on X. A clear communication from the leadership can prevent misinformation, restore confidence, and keep the cadre united and focused on the larger goal, he added.

As the suspicion of Annamalai's decision to resign grew, the BJP fishermen's wing state president, M C Munusamy, resigned from the party.

On June 2, Annamalai met party senior leader and Union Home Minister Amit Shah in the national capital amidst speculation of quitting the party. Though it was not officially made known what transpired during the 30-minute meeting between them, party sources indicated that Annamalai has been asked to put on hold his resignation plans for now. He has been sulking since he was replaced by Nainar Nagenthiran, and the party revived its electoral ties with the AIADMK.

Open to dialogue with govt, opposition; CBSE transfers 'eyewash': CJP

NEW DELHI: The Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) on Wednesday said it was ready for a dialogue with both the government and the Opposition over its demands, even as it prepared for a protest in the national capital later this week demanding the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the NEET and CBSE fiasco.

Addressing the party's first press conference at the Constitution Club of India here, CJP spokesperson Saurav Das, an independent journalist, dismissed the government's transfer of CBSE chairperson Rahul Singh and secretary Himanshu Gupta on Tuesday as an "eyewash".

The party appealed to



CJP chief spokespersons Vijeta Dahiya, Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka PTI

young people from across the country to participate in the proposed protest. "We have given an open call. Anybody can join us without a party banner. We are ready to have a dialogue with everybody, be it those in power or the Opposition," Das said, referring to CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke's call for a protest on June 6.

"We are demanding accountability in the system. We have been demanding the resignation of the education minister, but no action has been taken against him till date. The transfers are being projected as action. It's not. There's a rot in the system," Das added.

On May 22, the Delhi High Court issued Das a notice alongside AAP leader Gopal Rai on a plea seeking contempt proceedings against them over an alleged "orchestrated social media campaign" against Justice Swarnan Kanta Sharma, who recently withdrew from hearing the Delhi excise case.

Das said upon landing in Delhi at 8 AM on June 6, Dipke will head to Delhi's Parliament Street Police Station.

SIR work: BLOs, supervisors to get Rs 6K one-time honorarium

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: The ECI has announced a one-time honorarium of Rs 6,000 each for BLOs and BLO supervisors engaged in the SIR process.

In a directive issued to chief electoral officers of several states and Union Territories, including West Bengal, the Commission said the decision was taken in recognition of the extensive work involved in the revision exercise and the crucial role played by field-level staff.

The one-time payment will be made in addition to the regular remuneration and annual allowances already received by BLOs and supervisors, the

The Directive

» In a directive issued to chief electoral officers of several states and Union Territories, including West Bengal, the Commission said the decision was taken in recognition of the extensive work involved in the revision exercise and the crucial

role played by field-level staff

» The communication has been sent to officials in West Bengal, UP, Gujarat, Kerala, Rajasthan, Tamil Nadu, Madhya Pradesh, Goa, Puducherry, Lakshadweep, the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, and Chandigarh.

directive said.

The communication has been sent to officials in West Bengal, UP, Gujarat, Kerala, Rajasthan, Tamil Nadu, Madhya Pradesh, Goa, Puducherry, Lakshadweep, the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, and

Chandigarh.

The directive has asked state election authorities to inform all concerned officials and employees about the decision and take the necessary administrative steps for its implementation.

Karnataka Cabinet : A mix of old & new guards

Congress blends continuity and change in Karnataka power structure

BENGALURU: Thirteen legislators were sworn in as ministers in DK Shivakumar's Cabinet in Karnataka on Wednesday. Here is a brief profile.

G Parameshwara

A trusted organisational hand of the Congress and one of its most prominent Dalit faces in Karnataka, Parameshwara returned to the post of Deputy Chief Minister, marking yet another milestone in a political career spanning more than three decades.

The 74-year-old leader, who has spent years strengthening the Congress party's grassroots network in Karnataka, has long been regarded as one of the party's most disciplined and dependable administrators. His elevation as Deputy CM in the D K Shivakumar-led government is widely seen as recognition of his enduring contribution to the organisation and governance. He represents the Koratagere assembly segment in Tumkur district.

Satish Jarkiholi

A six-time MLA, he was the Public Works Minister in the previous Siddaramaiah government. Hailing from the



Congress MLA G Parameshwara takes oath PTI

Valmiki tribal community, the 64-year-old Jarkiholi belongs to a politico-business family, which owns a sugar factory. He represents Yamakanamaradi in Belagavi.

Priyank Kharge

The 47-year-old Congress leader is the son of AICC chief Mallikarjun Kharge. The Dalit leader had held Information Technology, Bio Technology, and Rural Development and Panchayat Raj portfolios in the Siddaramaiah government. The Chittapur MLA is known for his fiery stand against the BJP and the RSS.

UT Khader Fareed

Key Points

- » Parameshwara returned to the post of Deputy Chief Minister, marking yet another milestone in a political career spanning more than three decades
- » Krishna Byre Gowda (53) is one of the known Vokkaliga faces in Karnataka. He served as revenue minister in the Siddaramaiah-led Congress government in the state

Having served as the Assembly Speaker during the Siddaramaiah government, 56-year-old Khader is a strong minority face in the Congress from coastal Karnataka. He had held various portfolios in the past, including health and family welfare, food and civil supplies, urban development and housing. He represents Mangaluru constituency in Dakshina Kannada district.

Krishna Byre Gowda

Krishna Byre Gowda (53) is one of the known Vokkaliga faces in Karnataka. He served as revenue minister in the Siddaramaiah-led Congress gov-

ernment in the state. Gowda holds an MA degree in International Affairs from American University in Washington, DC, and a BBM degree from Christ University. His father, C Byre Gowda, was the Deputy Speaker and Minister of Agriculture in the Karnataka Legislative Assembly. Krishna Byre Gowda represents Byatarayanapura Assembly segment.

KH Muniyappa

He belongs to the Madiga community of the Scheduled Caste and was the Civil Supplies and Public Distribution Minister in Siddaramaiah government. The 78-year-old was a seven-time MP from Kolar and returned to state politics in 2023. His daughter Roopakala is a Congress MLA. He represents Devanahalli constituency in Bengaluru rural.

Ramalinga Reddy

The 72-year-old MLA from BTM Layout in Bengaluru, Ramalinga Reddy held the Transport and Hindu Religious Endowment department in the Siddaramaiah government. He had in the past held the Home portfolio.

Yathindra Siddaramaiah

Son of the outgoing Chief

Minister Siddaramaiah, Yathindra belongs to the shepherd Kuruba community. A doctor by profession, Yathindra is a Congress MLC. He earlier served as MLA from Varuna assembly segment.

KJ George

Kelachandra Joseph George is a Malayali settled in Bengaluru. He had served as the Energy Minister in the Siddaramaiah government. He was the Home Minister in the previous Congress government (2013-2015). He represents Sarvagna Nagar in Bengaluru urban.

Eshwar Khandre

Son of former minister Bheemanna Khandre, 64-year-old Khandre, represents Bhalki assembly constituency. He had served as Forest, Environment and Ecology Minister in the previous Siddaramaiah government.

Sharan Prakash Patil

The 59-year-old senior Congress leader, a doctor by profession, is a prominent political face for the Lingayat community in Kalyana Karnataka region. He served as the Medical Education and Skill Development Minister under Siddaramaiah.

Nation Briefs

J'KHAND CM EMPHASISES INCREASING GOLD PRODUCTION FROM STATE MINES

RANCHI: Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren on Wednesday stressed the need to increase gold production from the state's mines to give fresh momentum to the state's economic development. Reviewing the seven gold mines currently operating in the state, Soren directed officials to focus specifically on the gold mining sector and strengthen it through technological upgradation, attracting investments, and effective management, an official statement said.

ASSAM CM CALLS ON PRESIDENT MURMU, OUTLINES STATE'S GROWTH TRAJECTORY

NEW DELHI/GUWAHATI: Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Wednesday called on President Droupadi Murmu at the Rashtrapati Bhavan and briefed her on his government's plan about Assam's ongoing journey as the fastest-growing state. The President's office shared a picture of the meeting in a post on X. "Chief Minister of Assam Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma called on President Droupadi Murmu at Rashtrapati Bhavan," it said. Sarma also visited Granth Kutir in Rashtrapati Bhavan and viewed the collection of manuscripts. Through a rich collection of manuscripts and books in 11 classical languages of India, Granth Kutir showcases India's rich and diverse cultural, philosophical, literary and intellectual heritage, the President's office said in another post.

RODRIGUEZ IS SCHEDULED TO HOLD WIDE-RANGING TALKS WITH PM MODI TODAY

Venezuela’s acting Prez Rodriguez arrives in India

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi: Venezuelan Vice President Delcy Rodriguez arrived in India on Wednesday on a five-day visit to expand energy cooperation, as New Delhi seeks to diversify its crude oil procurement amid supply disruptions from the West Asia crisis.

Besides energy, the two sides are also set to explore ways to shore up cooperation in areas of trade and investment, pharmaceuticals and technology.

Rodriguez is scheduled to hold wide-ranging talks with Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday.

“A warm welcome to Acting President Delcy Rodriguez of Venezuela on her arrival in New Delhi,” External Affairs Ministry spokes-



Acting President of Venezuela Delcy Rodriguez being received by officials upon her arrival, in New Delhi

person Randhir Jaiswal said on social media.

“The visit will further deepen India-Venezuela ties and build on the momentum in the bilateral partnership.”

Rodriguez took charge as Venezuela’s acting president following the detention of then president Nicolas Maduro by US forces in January.

India was once a major

Highlights

- » Two sides are also set to explore ways to shore up cooperation in areas of trade and investment, pharmaceuticals and technology
- » Rodriguez took charge

as Venezuela’s acting president following the detention of then president Nicolas Maduro by US forces in January

» The two countries have robust cooperation in the energy sector

processor of Venezuelan heavy crude, importing more than 4,00,000 barrels per day at peak levels, until sweeping US sanctions and rising compliance risks forcibly shut down purchases in 2020.

New Delhi started purchasing crude oil from Venezuela after the sanctions were lifted following Maduro’s capture. Indian oil marketing companies significantly ramped up crude oil sourcing

from Venezuela in the last few weeks largely due to the West Asia crisis.

The Venezuelan acting president is accompanied by several ministers, including the ministers of foreign affairs, economy and finance, science and technology, communication and information, and transportation.

The Venezuelan delegation will visit several sites connected with energy, pharmaceuticals and auto sectors to gain insights into India’s technological and industrial capabilities and to explore opportunities for collaboration.

India and Venezuela share a history of warm relations. A major thrust to the bilateral relationship was imparted by former president Hugo Chavez’s State visit to India in March 2005.

The two countries have robust cooperation in the energy sector.

ONGC Videsh Limited (OVL) has a joint venture with Corporacion Venezolana del Petroleo (CVP).

The joint venture is known as “PetroleraIndovenezolana SA” for the production and exploration of oil in the San Cristobal field, in which the OVL has a 40-per cent stake.

CBSE: Nearly 44,000 applications filed for re-evaluation

‘Please rely on official CBSE communications for correct information’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Takeaways

- » ‘Payment gateways of the SBI, Canara Bank, Bank of Baroda and Indian Bank are available on the verification and re-evaluation portal’
- » According to board, facility is available only to those students who have obtained scanned copies of their evaluated answer books

NEW DELHI: Nearly 44,000 students have availed the verification and re-evaluation facility for board exams and completed the application process till Wednesday morning, the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) has said.

The board said the online portal has received a total of 43,980 applications for verification and re-evaluation of answer sheets.

“The portal has accepted 4,924 applications for verification and 39,056 applications for re-evaluation (total of 43,980) as of 12 noon today,” the CBSE said in a post on X on Wednesday.

It said payment gateways of the State Bank of India (SBI), Canara Bank, Bank of Baroda and Indian Bank are available on the verification and re-evaluation portal, adding that students are not required to have an account with these banks to complete the payment process.

“Students need not have an account with these banks to complete payment but can use any of these payment gateways to make payments,” the board said.

“As of 9:30 am today, nearly 40,000 students have availed this facility and completed the application process successfully without any issues,” it added.

Candidates may use online payment options, including UPI, net banking, credit card and debit card, through the designated gateways, it said.

“Please rely on official CBSE communications for correct information,” the board added.

The portal was launched after a delay, with the CBSE having earlier said filing applications for verification and re-evaluation of answer books was expected to begin by May 29.

The development comes following concerns raised by some students and parents over the on-screen marking (OSM) system used by the board.

The CBSE has faced criticism from students and parents over technical glitches, payment failures and access-related issues during the verification and re-evaluation process.

The board launched the online portal on Tuesday for a verification of issues observed in scanned copies of answer books and re-evaluation of answers for students dissatisfied with their Class-12 board exam evaluation.

According to the board, the facility is available only to those students who have obtained scanned copies of their evaluated answer books.

UP targets 35% reduction in NCR air pollution

‘No PUC, No Fuel’ rule from October 1

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The Uttar Pradesh government has stepped up efforts to tackle worsening air pollution in the National Capital Region (NCR), unveiling a series of measures ranging from scrapping old vehicles and strengthening industrial monitoring to mechanised road cleaning and improved waste management.

As part of the strategy, a “No Pollution Under Control (PUC) Certificate, No Fuel” policy will be enforced at all 1,041 petrol pumps across the state’s NCR districts from October 1.

The decision was reviewed at a high-level meeting on air pollution control and air quality improvement chaired by Chief

Secretary S.P. Goyal. The state has set a target of reducing air pollution levels in the NCR region by 30 to 35 per cent this year and directed all departments to ensure coordinated and time-bound action.

The Chief Secretary emphasised the need for an integrated digital monitoring network comprising portals, mobile applications, GPS-based tracking systems and dashboards to monitor pollution-control activities in real time.

Officials informed the meeting that 2.619 million coverage vehicles have been identified across NCR districts. Between January and April this year, 37,156 vehicles were scrapped, while 460 were seized for violating regulations.

Haryana set for SIR of electoral rolls after 24 years

Door-to-door verification drive to begin in the state from June 15

MPOST BUREAU

Closer Look

- » The final electoral roll will be published on September 22, 2026

» Sreenivas stated that for the convenience of voters, Enumeration Forms will be made available in Hindi

CHANDIGARH: Haryana is set to undertake a Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls after nearly 24 years.

As per the directions of the Election Commission of India, the comprehensive exercise will be conducted from June 15 to July 14, 2026, during which door-to-door verification of voters will be carried out at the booth level. The final electoral roll will be published on September 22, 2026.

Haryana Chief Electoral Officer (CEO), A Sreenivas reviewed the preparations for the exercise through a video conference with all Deputy Commissioners-cum-District Election Officers on Wednesday. He directed that Electoral

Registration Officers (EROs), Assistant Electoral Registration Officers (AEROs), Booth Level Officers (BLOs) and Supervisors be provided timely training to ensure the successful implementation of the campaign.

During the meeting, the CEO expressed concern over the slow progress of electoral roll mapping in the state.

He informed that only 64.26 per cent of the mapping work has been completed so far, while districts such as Faridabad, Gurugram, Sonapat, Panipat and Panchkula have achieved

less than 60 per cent progress. Calling it a matter of concern, he directed the concerned districts to hold meetings with Resident Welfare Association (RWA) representatives to ensure public participation. He also announced that he would personally visit these districts next week to review the situation.

Sreenivas stated that for the convenience of voters, Enumeration Forms will be made available in Hindi and can be downloaded from the official website from June 5, 2026. He said that in cases where forms

are not returned, BLOs will collect information from neighbours to identify absent, shifted, deceased or duplicate voters. It will be mandatory for BLOs to visit every such household at least three times.

He clarified that if a voter is not present at home, any adult member of the family may sign the Enumeration Form and submit it to the BLO. Even in cases where voters submit forms online, BLOs will conduct physical verification through house visits.

The Chief Electoral Officer further informed that voters whose names do not appear in the draft electoral roll will be listed booth-wise and displayed on notice boards at Panchayat Bhawans, Urban Local Body offices and BDPO offices.

Hooda chairs Congress legislature party meeting



MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: The Congress has decided to raise inflation, paper Leaks, power & water supply and law & order in the upcoming session of the Haryana Vidhan Sabha.

This was decided at a meeting of the Congress Legislature Party (CLP) was held under the chairmanship of former Chief Minister and Leader of the Opposition, Bhupinder Singh Hooda.

The meeting commenced with a two-minute silence to pay tribute to the late former Chief Minister, Chaudhary Bhajan Lal. All legislators remembered the late Bhajan Lal and paid their respects to him.

During the meeting, detailed discussions were held on numerous significant issues of public interest, and a future strategy was formulated.

Congress legislators voiced their concerns on a wide range of issues, including the burden of inflation, the continuously rising prices of petrol, diesel, and LPG, the SIR (Summary Revision of Electoral Rolls), bank scams, paper leaks, the NEET examination, exam cancellations, recruitment cancellations, CBSE paper evaluation, the deteriorating state of law and order, and shortages of electricity and water.

All members suggested launching a major agitation across the state.

Hooda instructed all members, including legislators, district-level leaders, and Booth Level Agents (BLAs) to play an active role with full vigour in the SIR process until July 15. He urged them to remain vigilant against any form of irregularity.

All Congress members were directed to ensure that no valid vote is deleted from the rolls, and conversely, that no fraudulent votes are added.

UP Panchayat polls: HC seeks timeline

Questions appointment of village heads as administrators

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The Lucknow bench of the Allahabad High Court on Wednesday took a stern view of the Uttar Pradesh government’s decision to appoint outgoing Gram Pradhans as administrators of village Panchayats after the completion of their tenure and sought a clear timeline for the conduct of Panchayat elections in the state.

A division bench comprising Justice Shekhar B Saraf and Justice Avadhesh Kumar Chaudhary directed the State Election Commission to inform the court on the next date of hearing about when elections to Gram Panchayats would be held. The court also asked the commission to provide the proposed election schedule.

The bench passed the order while hearing a public interest



Allahabad High Court

litigation filed by Om Prakash Prajapati challenging the state government’s recent decision to appoint outgoing village heads as administrators in their respective Gram Panchayats after the expiry of their terms.

The petitioner has argued that the government’s move is contrary to the spirit of the law governing local self-government institutions.

During the previous hearing on Tuesday, the state government had requested that the matter be taken up on June 3. The court had accordingly listed the case for hearing on Wednesday.

Senior advocate Amaren-

dra Nath Tripathi, appearing for the petitioner, said the court has now directed the State Election Commission to place before it a timeline for conducting Panchayat elections.

The court also rejected the state’s contention that the dedicated Other Backward Classes (OBC) Commission, constituted for determining reservation in Panchayat elections, would take six months to submit its report. Instead, the bench directed the state government to place the commission’s report before the court on the next date of hearing, fixed for July 10.

The Uttar Pradesh government had constituted a dedicated OBC Commission to recommend reservation arrangements for Panchayat seats, and had earlier indicated that elections could be held only after the commission submitted its findings.

Nazneen Ansari held in Heera Group money laundering case

HYDERABAD: The Directorate of Enforcement (ED), Hyderabad Zonal Office, has arrested Nazneen Ansari alias Abeeda under Section 19 of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002, on June 2, 2026, in connection with the Heera Group case involving the alleged defrauding of investors.

ED initiated its investigation after numerous complaints were filed in Telangana and Andhra Pradesh.

These filings targeted Nowhera Shaik along with entities tied to the Heera Group. Suspicion arose due to patterns suggesting investor funds had been gathered under misleading promises. Legal steps followed, prompted by claims of financial deception involving substantial sums.

Haryana Chief Minister’s ‘Go Global’ approach gets a new boost

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Giving a fresh momentum to this ‘Go Global’ approach, Haryana’s Farmer Producer Organisations (FPOs) will now be able to explore farming and agribusiness opportunities in Tanzania, Kenya and other African countries.

In the presence of Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini at Morni in Panchkula district, an agreement was signed between the country’s renowned spice company MDH and six Farmer Producer Organisations (FPOs) of Haryana.

The initiative, being implemented by the Department of Foreign Cooperation and the Horticulture Department, aims to connect farmers with global markets, enhance their income and create new opportunities in the agriculture sector.

Addressing a dialogue



programme, the Chief Minister said that in this year’s Budget, the government had announced the development of the Morni region. In line with that announcement, the MoU has been signed today to promote natural farming in the area.

He assured that farmers adopting natural farming would be compensated in case of any losses. In addition, the company will offer farmers practising natural farming a price that is 10 per cent higher than the prevailing market rate. He

said that the government’s target is to initiate natural farming on approximately 4,000 acres in the first phase.

The Chief Minister said that the Haryana government does not want farmers to remain confined to traditional farming practices. Instead, it seeks to connect them with agricultural entrepreneurship, value addition and international trade, thereby making them self-reliant and prosperous. Keeping this objective in mind, continuous efforts are being made to ensure farmers gain access to global markets.

Under the agreement, commercial cultivation of various spice crops, including ginger, turmeric and chilli, will be promoted in the Morni region of Panchkula district. MDH will provide farmers with technical guidance, support for quality production, marketing assistance and procurement support.

‘Cadets Sukhraj & Jasnoor made Punjab proud’

Aman Arora lauds AFCAT achievers

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: In a remarkable feat, two cadets from the 10th course of Maharaja Ranjit Singh Armed Forces Preparatory Institute (MRSAPFI), Mohali, have clinched the 2nd and 6th All-India ranks in the Air Force Common Admission Test (AFCAT) II examination.

The achievers are Sukhraj Singh Heera, who bagged AIR 2, is son of government school teacher from Ropar district and cadet Jasnoor Singh of Pathankot, secured AIR 6.

Notably, both the cadets have already been selected for Combined Defence Services (CDS) courses set to commence later this month.

In the CDS merit list, Jasnoor Singh stood first in the Air Force category, while Sukhraj Singh Heera secured the fourth rank in the Army merit list. Their dual success in AFCAT and CDS underscores the rigorous training and mentorship provided at the institute.

Congratulating the cadets, Punjab Employment Generation, Skill Development and Training Minister, Aman Arora

Notably, both the cadets have already been selected for Combined Defence Services courses set to commence later this month

said the achievement reflects the talent and grit of Punjab’s youth.

Sukhraj and Jasnoor have made the entire state proud. Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann led state government is committed to strengthening defence preparatory institutes like MRSAPFI and Mai Bhago AFPI so that more youth from ordinary backgrounds can earn commissions in the armed forces, he added.

Director of MRSAPFI Major General Ajay H Chauhan, VSM (Retd.), lauded both the cadets, while stating that around 24 cadets of the institute are in the process of receiving joining letters for courses commencing shortly at training academies across the country.



EDITORIAL
FATAL
NEGLECT

The devastating fire at a bed-and-breakfast establishment in Delhi's Malviya Nagar, which has claimed at least 21 lives, is not merely another tragic accident. It is also a grim reminder of a recurring pattern that has become all too familiar in India: warnings are issued, recommendations are made, courts intervene, and yet meaningful action remains elusive until lives are lost. The revelation that the Delhi High Court had, nearly five months ago, directed authorities to formulate a comprehensive action plan to strengthen fire safety standards across hotels, restaurants and hospital-ity establishments makes the tragedy even more disturbing. This was not a case of unforeseen danger. The risks had already been identified. The court had already acknowledged them. The administration had already been instructed to act. Yet the system appears to have done what it often does best — delay, defer and forget. Twenty-one people have now paid the price for that failure.

Urban India has witnessed a horrifying succession of fire disasters over the years. From hospitals and coaching centres to fac-tories, restaurants and commercial com-plexes, the causes are depressingly similar: blocked exits, unauthorised construction, overcrowding, poor maintenance, faulty electrical systems, absence of firefighting equipment and lax enforcement of regu-lations. Every major incident is followed by inspections, notices, suspensions and promises of reform. Yet once public atten-tion shifts elsewhere, compliance mech-anisms weaken and business returns to normal. Delhi's hospitality sector appears to be no exception. The petition before the High Court highlighted concerns about establishments operating in con-gested neighbourhoods with narrow access roads and limited evacuation routes. It also pointed to a startling gap between licensed establishments and those holding valid fire safety clearances. Perhaps most troubling was the suggestion that even after fire safety approvals are granted, violations often go unchecked because regular inspections are either inadequate or absent. This exposes a fundamental weakness in India's regulatory culture. Compliance is frequently treated as a one-time certification exercise rather than a continuous responsibility. A fire safety certificate framed on a wall is meaningless if emergency exits are blocked six months later or if building usage changes without oversight.

The issue extends beyond individ-ual businesses. It raises serious questions about governance and accountability. Courts can issue directions, laws can prescribe standards and departments can draft regulations, but public safety ultimately depends on enforcement. If a High Court directive remains unat-tended despite repeated reminders from the petitioner, it reflects a troubling dis-connect between judicial intent and administrative action. The larger con-cern is that accountability often disap-pears after disasters occur. Establishment owners may face criminal charges, local officials may be suspended and compen-sation may be announced, but systemic responsibility remains elusive. Rarely are there consequences for regulatory neg-ligence, delayed inspections or failure to act on documented warnings. This cul-ture of impunity encourages compla-cency. It allows violations to accumulate until they culminate in catastrophe. Effec-tive fire safety requires more than reactive firefighting. It demands routine audits, transparent disclosure of compliance sta-tus, digital monitoring of safety certi-fications, surprise inspections and clearly defined responsibility at every adminis-trative level. Most importantly, officials who ignore known risks must face conse-quences comparable to those imposed on private operators.

Delhi's latest tragedy should there-fore become a turning point rather than another entry in a growing cata-logue of preventable disasters. The city needs a comprehensive safety audit of all hospitality establishments, particu-larly those operating in densely popu-lated neighbourhoods. Fire safety data should be publicly accessible so that citizens can make informed choices. Renewal of licences must be linked to periodic compliance verification rather than paperwork alone. Most importantly, governments must recognise that public safety cannot be treated as an adminis-trative formality. Every ignored inspec-tion report, every delayed audit and every unimplemented court directive carries human consequences. The victims of the Malviya Nagar fire did not die because India lacks laws or regulations. They died because those laws failed to translate into action. If this tragedy does not finally compel authorities to move from prom-ises to enforcement, then the next disaster is not a question of if, but when.

NEXUS
OF GOOD



ANIL SWARUP

THE WRITER IS
AN AUTHOR AND
A FORMER
CIVIL SERVANT

For thousands of tribal students, a bench, a meal, a mentor or a scholarship can become the first step towards breaking generations of poverty

Transforming Tribal Education

In Maharashtra's Shahapur Taluka, Ananya Foundation and Bajaj Group Trusts have quietly built a model of tribal education reform that goes far beyond classrooms and textbooks

In the tribal heartland of Maharashtra's Thane district, a quiet educa-tional transformation is taking place. For nearly two decades, the Mumbai-based Ananya Foundation, along with the Bajaj Group Trusts, have been working to improve educational opportunities for thousands of socially and economically disadvantaged students in Shahapur Taluka — one of the largest and under-served regions in the district. Founded in 2007 by Rajesh V Shah, the initiatives began as part of the CSR initiatives of Mukand Ltd and were initially supported by the Bajaj Group Trusts. Today, the initiatives are implemented by Ananya Foundation - a public charitable trust, which contin-ues the mission of strengthening education and creating sustain-able livelihood opportunities for tribal adolescents.

Every year, the Founda-tion supports nearly 9,500 students studying in Classes 8, 9 and 10 across 45 govern-ment-aided schools in Shaha-pur Taluka. The interventions focus not only on improving academic performance but also on reducing school drop-outs, addressing malnutrition, enhancing life skills, and creat-ing pathways to higher educa-tion and employment. A Region Facing Deep Educa-tional Challenges

Shahapur Taluka covers nearly 1,629 square kilome-tres and accounts for almost 39 per cent of the geographical area of Thane district. Despite supplying water to Mumbai and Thane through its major lakes, the region continues to struggle with poverty, low lit-eracy levels and limited access to quality education.

According to Census data cited by the Foundation, over 35 per cent of the population belongs to Scheduled Tribes, while literacy levels remain sig-nificantly below urban averages. Female literacy is particularly concerning. Many parents of current Class 10 students have themselves studied only up to Class 8 or below.

Economic hardship, migra-tion, weak educational infra-structure and limited exposure to career opportunities have historically contributed to high dropout rates among adoles-cents. In many villages, students lacked basic facilities such as benches, fans, toilets, uniforms, textbooks and nutritious meals.



Nutrition, infrastructure, mentoring and community trust can transform tribal education from the grassroots

Recognising these inter-connected challenges, Ananya Foundation adopted a holistic intervention model that com-bines academic support with nutritional assistance, infra-structure development, sports, counselling and career guidance. Visible Improvement in Aca-demic Outcomes

One of the most signifi-cant indicators of the Founda-tion's impact has been the steady improvement in Class 10 exami-nation performance among stu-dents from intervention schools.

Data from the Foundation's presentation shows that pass per-centages in the 45 schools have improved substantially over the years. The percentage of students scoring above 60 per cent has also increased significantly com-pared to earlier years.

Even during periods when state-wide SSC examination per-formance witnessed declines, schools supported by the Founda-tion continued to perform comparatively better than neigh-bouring tribal regions with simi-lar socio-economic conditions.

Educational support has been one of the Foundation's strongest pillars. Over the last decade:

- More than 15,000 students benefited from free mathe-matics support classes held after school hours.
- Nearly 30,000 students received textbooks.
- More than one lakh students received notebooks.
- Thousands of students were provided schoolbags, com-press boxes and footwear.

The Foundation states that these interventions have contributed to increased school attendance, improved confidence among stu-dents and stronger learning outcomes.

Beyond Academics: Tackling Hunger and Infrastructure Gaps

The Foundation's work extends far beyond classrooms. Teachers and local adminis-trators observed that many students left school after an hour or so because of hunger, fatigue and lack of concentra-tion. Nutritional support pro-grammes introduced by the organisation have therefore become a critical component of its educational strategy.

Over 45,000 students have received nutritional snacks, while school uniforms have been distributed to more than one lakh children over the years. Midday meals have also been provided to thou-sands of students.

Infrastructure development has similarly played a transfor-mative role. The Foundation has distributed benches and classroom fans across multiple schools, repaired school build-ings and helped build or restore toilet facilities. According to the organisation, every high school in Shahapur now has separate functional toilets for boys and girls, as well as benches and fans in classrooms.

These seemingly basic facili-ties have had a profound impact on dignity, attendance and retention, particularly for ado-lescent girls.

Sports, Confidence and Holis-tic Development

Ananya Foundation believes education must go beyond textbooks. Cultural activities, exposure visits and sports pro-grammes are regularly organ-ised to encourage confidence and creativity among students.

Among the Foundation's notable initiatives are the Mukand Shahapur Road Races, which have provided tribal stu-dents with opportunities to par-ticipate in organised sporting events. Annual cultural pro-grammes also offer platforms for students to showcase talents that often remain hidden due to social and economic constraints.

The organisation hopes to establish specialised sports cen-tres that will provide profes-sional training to students in selected disciplines. Scholar-ships for transport and nutri-tion support are also proposed for talented sports students.

The Next Five Years: Building a Comprehensive Education Model

With growing community trust and measurable outcomes, Ananya Foundation is now pre-paring for an expanded five-year strategy aimed at making Shahapur a model taluka for school education.

The Foundation's future roadmap is built around four major pillars.

The first pillar focuses on strengthening foundational lit-eracy and numeracy among Class 8 students through after-school support classes in math-ematics, Marathi and English. Local educated youth will be

trained and employed as com-munity educators, creating both educational and livelihood opportunities.

The second pillar emphasises digital literacy and life skills. Planned interventions include computer training, mobile sci-ence laboratories, reading pro-grammes, competitions, field visits and exposure activities to build curiosity and aspirations among students.

The third pillar addresses physical and emotional well-being through nutrition pro-grammes, sports training and educational support for eco-nomically vulnerable students.

The fourth pillar focuses on career exposure and skilling for Class 10 students. Career coun-selling, scholarships, personal-ity assessments and support for admissions into higher educa-tion institutions, ITIs and poly-technic colleges will form a key part of this strategy.

The Foundation also intends to establish a hub-and-spoke implementation structure con-sisting of central resource cen-tres connected to school-based learning units.

A Vision Beyond Shahapur

What distinguishes Ananya Foundation's approach is its emphasis on long-term trans-formation rather than short-term charity. Its leadership believes that meaningful educational reform in tribal communities requires contin-uous engagement with schools, parents, local youth and com-munity leaders. It is a wonder-ful example of Nexus of Good. The model can be replicated and scaled through public-pri-vate partnership.

The Foundation hopes its Shahapur model can eventu-ally be replicated in other tribal talukas across Thane district and beyond.

At a time when conversa-tions around education often focus on technology and urban institutions, Ananya Founda-tion's work highlights the con-tinuing importance of grassroots educational interventions in rural India.

For thousands of tribal stu-dents in Shahapur, access to a classroom bench, a nutritious meal, a mentor or a scholar-ship can become the first step towards breaking generations of poverty.

And for Ananya Founda-tion, that transformation has only just begun.

Views expressed are personal

QUIET
WITHDRAWAL



ASIF ULLAH KHAN

THE WRITER
HAS WORKED IN
SENIOR EDITORIAL
POSITIONS FOR
MANY RENOWNED
INTERNATIONAL
PUBLICATIONS

For decades, Indian Americans represented one of the great immigrant success stories. Yet a growing number now report feeling less secure expressing their identity openly

Fear Between the Lines

A new survey reveals that many Indian Americans are not leaving the United States, but are increasingly modifying how they speak, dress, socialise and participate in public life

What does it mean when members of a community begin speaking less, hid-ing more, and thinking twice before expressing who they are? For a growing number of Indian Americans, that question has become increasingly relevant during Donald Trump's second term. Some avoid political discussions online. Others are reluctant to display their political views publicly. Some think twice before wearing traditional Indian attire in public. Others have become more cautious about attending protests, rallies, and other public gatherings.

These are not dramatic acts of pro-test or resistance. They are quiet acts of self-preservation. Yet taken together, they point to a troubling reality: concerns about discrimination, racial hostility, and online abuse are increasingly shap-ing how Indian Americans navigate pub-lic life in the United States. The unease is not entirely unfounded. In recent years, even some of the most prominent Indian-origin figures in American politics have found themselves targets of racial attacks. Kash Patel, one of the most influen-tial Indian Americans in the Trump admin-istration, has frequently been subjected to racist abuse online. Former South Carolina governor Nikki Haley has long faced taunts about her Indian heritage and birth name, while Usha Vance, the wife of Vice President JD Vance, has been the target of xenophobic commentary on social media. Their prominence may have brought them national visibility, but it has not shielded them from questions about identity and belonging that many Indian Americans know all too well.

If public figures occupying some of the highest offices and circles of power



The erosion of belonging reveals itself gradually, through countless small acts of self-censorship and self-preservation

in the United States remain vulnerable to such attacks, it is hardly surprising that ordinary Indian Americans are reassessing how openly they express them-selves in public.

A new nationally representative survey of 1,000 Indian Americans conducted by the Carnegie Endowment for Inter-national Peace suggests that this reassessment is already underway. Nearly one-third of respondents say they avoid political discussions on social media for fear of becoming targets. Around one-fifth report avoiding public displays of their political beliefs, limiting partici-pation in political events, being more cautious about travel, or thinking twice before wearing Indian attire in public.

The survey reveals a community grappling not only with discrimina-

tion but also with its psychological consequences. Nearly half of Indian Americans say they frequently encoun-ter racist content targeting Indians or Indian Americans online. About half report feeling angry when exposed to such content. One-third experience anx-iety or fear. Roughly one-quarter report feelings of hopelessness.

These emotions do not remain con-fined to digital spaces. They shape behav-iour, influence participation in public life, and affect an individual's sense of belonging. The most important finding of the survey is that four in 10 Indian Americans have at some point considered leaving the United States deserves closer scrutiny. On its own, the statistic suggests a community contemplating an exodus. But the survey tells a more nuanced story.

Most Indian Americans are not pack-ing their bags. Only a small minority say they frequently think about leaving, and among those who have considered it, many are not contemplating a return to India. More importantly, most con-tinue to see the United States as a land of opportunity and have deep professional, financial, and family roots in the country. However, many are learning to navigate an America that feels less welcoming than before. They are adjusting their behaviour in ways both subtle and significant.

In that sense, the survey's most con-sequential finding is not about physical departure but psychological retreat. The question is not whether Indian Amer-icans are leaving the United States. It is whether they are beginning to feel less at home within it.

A society can lose a sense of belong-ing long before it loses its people. Commu-nities do not need to emigrate for discrimi-nation to leave its mark. Sometimes the effects are visible in quieter ways — in conversations that never happen, opin-ions left unspoken, cultural expressions toned down, and public spaces entered with greater hesitation than before.

That may be the most important warn-ing contained in the Carnegie survey. The erosion of belonging rarely announces itself dramatically. It reveals itself gradu-ally, through countless small acts of self-censorship and self-preservation.

For a community that has spent decades building deep roots in Amer-ican society, the more pressing question is no longer whether opportunity exists. It is whether success alone can guarantee a sense of security, dignity, and belong-ing in an increasingly polarised America.

Views expressed are personal

GLOBAL FUEL PRICES REMAIN HIGH AMID CONFLICT

US-Iran trade strikes in Persian Gulf in new test of ceasefire

DUBAI: Kuwait briefly shut its main airport Wednesday after Iranian drones heavily damaged a terminal building, killed one person and wounded dozens — the latest in back-and-forth attacks by Tehran and Washington that have tested a fragile ceasefire.

Semiofficial Iranian news agencies have said Tehran had stopped communicating with mediators about extending the ceasefire in the war with the US and Israel. A regional official said Iran wanted a separate ceasefire in Lebanon enforced before returning to talks. US President Donald Trump asserted that negotiations continued.

The talks have dragged on for weeks, and exchanges of strikes in the Gulf region and Israel's broadening war with the Iranian-backed Hezbollah in Lebanon are further strains.

Iran maintains its hold on the Strait of Hormuz — a crucial waterway for the world's oil and natural gas and related products like fertilizer — and the U.S. continues its blockade of Iranian ports. Global fuel prices remain high, and the effects of the conflict are felt well beyond the region.

Iran's Fars and Tasnim news agencies, both believed to be close to the Guard, on Tuesday reported that Iran's negotiators have stopped communicating with ceasefire mediators as tensions flare in Israel's separate but related fight against Hezbollah in Lebanon.

A regional official involved in the mediation, speaking on condition of anonymity to discuss the talks, told The Asso-



Rescuers work at the site of an Israeli airstrike that hit a building and damaged a hospital, being seen in the background, in Tyre

Israel strikes just south of Beirut ahead of 2nd day of ceasefire talks

BEIRUT: An Israeli strike Wednesday hit a car on a busy highway just south of Beirut, hours before the second day of talks between Lebanon and Israel in Washington is set to take place.

The strike in Khaldah came without warning, and it was not immediately clear if the person targeted was killed. Israel usually says it targets members of the Hezbollah militant group in these drone strikes.

Israel and Lebanon on

ciated Press that Iran had not communicated on Tuesday after saying a ceasefire needed to be enforced in Lebanon for negotiations to continue.

Trump called reports of a cessation in talks "false and erroneous."

"The conversations between

Monday reached a US-brokered agreement where Israel would not strike Beirut's southern suburbs, and Hezbollah would end its attacks on northern Israel.

The agreement was made hours after Israel announced that it was going to launch strikes across the sprawling urban neighbourhoods near the Lebanese capital in what would have been the most intense strikes since a nominal ceasefire went into effect on April 17.

AGENCIES

have been going on continuously, including four days ago, three days ago, two days ago, one day ago and today," Trump said in a social media post Tuesday.

Israeli forces have moved deeper into Lebanon than at any time in over a quarter-century,

Highlights

- » A regional official said Iran wanted a separate ceasefire in Lebanon enforced before returning to talks
- » Trump called reports of a cessation in talks 'false and erroneous'
- » The fighting has exposed a rift between close allies Israel and the U.S., with US pushing for restraint

while Hezbollah has launched rocket and drone attacks. The declared ceasefire in Lebanon is officially in place and no side has formally withdrawn or declared it over even as attacks continue.

Lebanon has emerged as a sticking point in Trump's efforts to sign a ceasefire deal with Iran. Tehran insists that any larger potential truce must quell the fighting in Lebanon. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu wants to keep the issues separate and is under domestic pressure to strike Hezbollah as he prepares for elections this fall. The fighting has exposed a rift between close allies Israel and the U.S., with the US pushing for restraint.

In a podcast interview released Wednesday, Trump confirmed a report that he had called Netanyahu "crazy" Monday in a phone call peppered with an expletive. Trump told The New York Post's "Pod Force One" that he was "a little bit perturbed" that Israel's fight with Hezbollah was holding back talks with Iran.

Ukrainian drones hit St. Petersburg oil terminal ahead of 'Russian Davos'

KYIV: Ukrainian long-range drones struck an oil terminal in St. Petersburg and set it ablaze, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Wednesday, as the Russian city hosts an annual international economic forum that is a banner event for President Vladimir Putin.

The drones flew more than 1,000 kilometres to hit the terminal, Zelenskyy said on social media.

Clouds of black smoke rose over the city's port after the attack. St. Petersburg is Russia's second-largest city and is where Putin was born.

Russian authorities said only that the Ukrainian drone strike targeted the city's infrastructure, without providing further details. The airport of St. Petersburg briefly suspended flights overnight because of the attack. Authorities also cut off mobile internet services.

With the front line changing little as swarms of drones



A bus being seen a damaged by Ukrainian drone in Yennakieve, in Donetsk

“THE DRONES FLEW MORE THAN 1,000 KILOMETRES TO HIT THE TERMINAL”

hinder battlefield movement, both sides have sought an edge by increasingly launching long-range strikes.

The war that followed Rus-

sia's invasion of its neighbour has now stretched into its fifth year, with no end in sight.

The latest strikes are an embarrassment for Putin, weeks after he pruned back an annual Victory Day parade in Moscow due to fears of Ukrainian drone attacks.

Putin is set to speak on Friday at the economic forum in St. Petersburg that the Kremlin views as a prestigious event.

AGENCIES

Ex-Thai PM Thaksin freed early from parole after receiving royal pardon

BANGKOK: Thailand's former Prime Minister Thaksin Shinawatra formally completed all his obligations related to a prison sentence on Wednesday, when a royal pardon ended his four-month probation early.

The 76-year-old billionaire populist, who was a dominant force in Thai politics for more than two decades, was released from a Bangkok prison last month to cheering crowds.

There has since been speculation that he might continue to exert his strong influence over the Pheu Thai Party, which is part of the governing coalition, though his family has said he may want to step back from politics.

AGENCIES

Trump confirms calling Netanyahu 'crazy'

The US President says that Tel Aviv complicating peace talks with Iran

BEIRUT: President Donald Trump in an interview released Wednesday confirmed an earlier report that he criticised Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu as "crazy" in a Monday phone call, saying he was "a little bit perturbed" that Israel's fighting of Hezbollah in Lebanon was holding back peace talks with Iran.

But even as the US president acknowledged the tensions, he insisted that his relationship with Netanyahu was solid and they



US President Donald Trump

connected, in part, because they're both "wartime" leaders. "We've worked very well together. I like Bibi a lot. And I work very well with him," Trump told

The New York Post's "Pod Force One."

The president's acknowledgement of the tense call with Netanyahu that involved expletives is a sign of the growing pressure he faces to resolve the Iran war, as higher energy prices and economic uncertainty are harming Republicans going into midterm elections and hampering global commerce.

But Trump remained noncommittal about a timeline for settling the conflict,

saying the Strait of Hormuz might stay blocked through the Labor Day holiday on September 7.

He has insisted that Iran stop any efforts that could lead to a nuclear weapon and that the strait be reopened for the shipments of oil and natural gas.

"I don't know. I mean, I think it could be (closed through Labor Day), but I think it's unlikely. I think that we'll have it. I think this will resolve itself fairly quickly," Trump said.

AGENCIES

Sri Lankan court bars ex-Prez Rajapaksa from foreign travel

COLOMBO: A Sri Lankan court on Wednesday imposed an overseas travel ban on former president Gotabaya Rajapaksa and two former military officers in connection with ongoing investigations into the 2019 Easter attack.

The Colombo Fort Magistrate's Court issued the order after considering a motion filed by the Criminal Investigation Department (CID), which is probing the coordinated suicide bombings that targeted churches and luxury hotels across the island nation on April 21, 2019, that killed 270 people, including 11 Indians.

The travel restrictions also apply to Army Colonel Mohamed Ansar and former intelligence officer Premananda Udalgama, also known as Silva.

Key Points

- » The travel restrictions also apply to Army Colonel Mohamed Ansar and former intelligence officer Premananda Udalgama
- » Sallay was serving in a diplomatic position overseas when the attack took place

Magistrate Pasan Amarasekara issued the order when the case involving former State Intelligence Service director Suresh Sallay was taken up before the court.

Sallay, who has been named as a suspect in the proceedings, is being held under detention orders

after his arrest on February 25 as part of efforts to identify the alleged mastermind behind the attacks.

Sallay was serving in a diplomatic position overseas when the attack took place. He headed the state intelligence service under the then-Mahinda Rajapaksa government prior to 2015.

Police told the court that ongoing investigations could be hampered if Gotabaya Rajapaksa and the two military officers were to flee the country.

Gotabaya Rajapaksa, the younger brother of former president Mahinda Rajapaksa, announced his candidacy for the presidency shortly after the bombings and went on to win the November 2019 election.

Kenya school fire: 9 students to be remanded for 21 days

NAIVASHA: Kenyan detectives on Wednesday were granted 21 days to hold nine students suspected of planning and executing an arson attack at a girl's boarding school in central Kenya that killed 16 children, in a case that has gripped the East African nation.

A court in the town of Naivasha ruled that the girls will be remanded at a children's home to allow investigators to complete their inquiries and determine whether to bring charges.

The fire on May 28 ripped through the Utumishi Girls School dormitory that houses 202 students. Investigators said the school matron failed to open an emergency door, forcing all students to scamper through a single doorway.

The accused girls have been in police custody for six days, during which interrogations revealed the fire was started by lighting a mattress at the dormitory's exit using a matchstick and paraffin. No motive has been revealed so far.

Police arrested nine girls after questioning students and reviewing CCTV footage that investigators say shows some students setting a fire inside the dormitory.

Hezron Mogire, a lawyer representing the nine girls, told the court there were "no compelling reasons" to detain the girls for 30 days, as requested by investigators.

"Nonetheless, the court has taken a different view. We have already briefed our clients, and

they are well informed," he said.

Mbogo Macharia, the lawyer representing the families of the 16 girls who died in the fire, called for a thorough investigation within 21 days.

"During that time, it is expected by the courts, by the nation, and also by us as the victims that the investigations will have concluded, we will have gotten the answers that we very much want to hear, and we will have found a way forward in respect to finding justice for the victims," he said.

The results of DNA tests to determine the identities of some of the bodies that were charred beyond recognition are expected later Wednesday.

AGENCIES

UK Royal Navy says 3 members died in helicopter crash during training exercise

LONDON: Britain's Royal Navy said Wednesday that three of its members died in a helicopter crash earlier in southwest England during a training exercise.

The helicopter went down in a field in the county of Devon in England just before 4 am.

The navy's head General Gwyn Jenkins, said in a statement that he was "deeply saddened to share the news that three crewmembers onboard a Royal Navy Merlin Mk4 helicopter have died after it crashed in the early hours of this morning near Sourton, Devon."

He said an investigation is under way and further updates will be provided later.

NASA declares Mars Maven spacecraft dead

LAUNCHED IN 2013 to study the red planet's atmosphere from orbit, Maven mysteriously fell silent in early Dec after passing behind Mars

CAPE CANAVERAL: After six months of radio silence, NASA's Maven spacecraft at Mars has been declared dead.

The space agency confirmed Wednesday that the mission had ended after more than a decade of observations.

Launched in 2013 to study the red planet's atmosphere from orbit, Maven mysteriously fell silent in early December after passing behind Mars. Data indicated the spacecraft went into a fast spin, which disrupted its orbit and drained the onboard batteries.

A review board convened by NASA earlier this year concluded that the spacecraft is useless and unable to be recovered. An investigation continues into what caused the problem.

Besides studying Martian weather and observing a stray interstellar comet last year,

Maven helped relay information from NASA's Curiosity and Perseverance rovers on the surface.

Maven's lead scientist, Shannon Curry of the University of Colorado Boulder, said the spacecraft made a number of "amazing discoveries."

Maven "has truly advanced our understanding of the Martian atmosphere and evolution," she said in a statement.

AGENCIES

British Sikh man's murder trial leads to anti-police protests in UK

LONDON: A British Sikh man's conviction for the murder of a teenager triggered violent clashes targeted at the police in the UK, after body-worn camera footage showed officers handcuffing the victim in his final moments over an allegation of racism.

Large crowds descended upon Southampton on Tuesday evening as officers from the Hampshire and Isle of Wight Constabulary lined up in riot protection gear near the home of Vickrum Digwa, sentenced to life imprisonment for stabbing 18-year-old Henry Nowak to death. They were pelted with bricks and bottles as the protesters heard from anti-immigration activists, who condemned so-called "two-tier policing" or prioritising one community over another. "There are serious questions to answer including how accusations of racism informed police thinking and we're supporting the IOPC to get to the bottom of what happened," British PM told the House of Commons on Wednesday.

AGENCIES

After decades of rising support, same-sex marriage acceptance may be stalling: Poll

Most of the change is due to dropping acceptance among Republicans

HADDONFIELD: Acceptance of same-sex marriage and relationships in the US has flattened after more than two decades of steadily increasing support, with an ongoing decline among Republicans, according to a new Gallup poll.

About 65 per cent of US adults believe same-sex marriage should be legal, down slightly from 71 per cent in 2022 and 2023.

Most of the change is due to dropping acceptance among Republicans. In the new survey, which was conducted in May, only 37 per cent of Republicans say same-sex marriage should be legally valid, while 35 per cent say gay and lesbian relations are "morally acceptable."

The widening partisan divide is also reflected in policy around LGBTQ+ issues across the US, particularly regarding transgender people, and a ris-



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

ing push in some states to ban same-sex marriage.

The downturn in support for same-sex marriage, while slight, is still striking because of how dramatically American views on the issue have shifted over the past few decades.

According to Gallup's trend data, only 27 per cent of US

adults supported legal same-sex marriage in 1996. Since then, support for same-sex marriage rose steadily until a few years ago, when it peaked with around 71 in 10 US adults saying same-sex marriage should be legal.

Opinion about the morality of same-sex relationships fol-

lowed the same pattern. About 4 in 10 US adults said same-sex relations were morally acceptable in 2001. That increased nearly 30 percentage points over the next two decades.

Over the past few years, Gallup's data has shown signs of a shift in the other direction. In addition to the slight

decline in same-sex marriage, the new poll also found that 62 per cent of US adults view gay and lesbian relations as morally acceptable, down from 71 per cent in 2022.

Same-sex marriage has been recognised nationally since a 2015 Supreme Court ruling. That case capped a 12-year run in which court rulings and state laws recognised it in most states.

By last year, there were more than 800,000 married same-sex couples, according to data compiled by the Williams Institute at the University of California, Los Angeles School of Law.

The pushback has never stopped, though. A call to overturn the 2015 ruling reached the Supreme Court last year, invoking the words of Justice Clarence Thomas, who has called for undoing it. The court turned away the appeal without comment.

Last year, the Southern Baptist Convention overwhelmingly called for reversing the ruling that led to nationwide marriage recognition and imposing a ban.

AGENCIES

NEPAL POLITICS

Oli rules out stepping down from CPN-UML’s leadership

KATHMANDU: Nepal’s former prime minister K P Sharma Oli said on Wednesday that he will not step down from the CPN-UML’s leadership, even as pressure mounted on him to resign from the party’s chairmanship to pave the way for the young leaders.

“There was no intention of becoming chair just to step aside when difficulties arise or to grab opportunities when things are easy,” 74-year-old Oli said while speaking at an event organised by the party in Kathmandu.

Oli stressed that he will continue leading the party until it achieves success. “Now I have gained health, and I will again reach out to the people,” he said.

After the defeat of the CPN-UML in the March 5 general election and also his own humiliating defeat at the hands of Prime Ministerial candidate Balendra Shah “Balen” in his stronghold at Jhapa-5 constituency, Oli was facing pressure



Nepal’s former prime minister K P Sharma Oli

from the young leaders of the party to resign.

According to party insiders, although the majority of the 19-member central secretariat of the party are opposed to Oli, the former prime minister still enjoys majority support in the 301-member central committee. The UML has formed a

task force led by the party’s vice president Ram Bahadur Thapa ‘Badal’ to prepare a report on the restructuring of the organisation and review of the general election in which the party won just 25 seats in the 275-member House of Representatives.

The report will be discussed at the central secretariat of the

Highlights

- » Oli stressed that he will continue leading the party until it achieves success
- » Oli was facing pressure from the young leaders of the party to resign
- » The report will be discussed at the central secretariat of the party before being presented to the Central Working Committee

party before being presented to the Central Working Committee (CWC).

The CWC will do whatever changes are necessary in the party, said central member Bishnu Rijal. The CWC has the authority even to change the leadership of the party, he added.

AGENCIES

‘FBI shoots man holding hostages in California office building’

SAN FRANCISCO: A man who was holding hostages inside a California office building for more than 15 hours was shot and killed by the FBI early Wednesday, police said.

The hostages were found unharmed inside the downtown Bakersfield building that houses a bank and a school district office, the Bakersfield Police Department said in a statement.

The suspect was killed in “an officer-involved shooting” involving FBI personnel around 4:20 a.m., the department said.

The standoff began around 1 p.m. Tuesday when officers responded to a call of a bomb threat at the Chase Bank building, a four-story office building with dark-tinted glass windows all around. Police said the man had barricaded himself inside with several people.

The department’s crisis negotiation team talked with

“WE HAVE EVERY SINGLE RESOURCE AT OUR DISPOSAL OUT HERE TO BRING THIS TO THE SAFEST RESOLUTION POSSIBLE”

the suspect by telephone and eventually two hostages were released Tuesday night, police said.

Nearby buildings, including City Hall and the police headquarters that are just a block away, were evacuated and some roads were temporarily closed during the hostage situation. Bakersfield, a city of about 380,000 residents, is the seat of largely rural Kern County and is about 100 miles (160 kms) northeast of Los Angeles.

A spokesperson for JPMor-

gan Chase said the bank branch is on the ground floor.

Officers established a perimeter around the area and warned the public to stay away.

“We have every single resource at our disposal out here to bring this to the safest resolution possible,” Bakersfield police Sgt. Eric Celedon said Tuesday.

Jacob Davidson, a livestreamer known as Dad’s Gone Live, was a block from the bank at his family’s tattoo shop when he started getting calls about the bomb threat.

“I went into the bank’s parking garage and watched the cops enter the back of the bank. This is the biggest police presence I’ve ever seen in this town,” Davidson said.

His livestream captured through a window in the building a woman rocking back and forth Tuesday night before crouching below the window.

AGENCIES

Trump to attend NATO summit in Turkey in July, says Rubio

WASHINGTON: U.S. President Donald Trump will attend the NATO meeting of heads of state that is taking place in Turkey in July, U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio said on Wednesday, providing a confirmation that will likely lead to a sigh of relief across the capitals of the alliance.

While American presidents almost always attend NATO summits given Washington is the leader of the alliance, questions were raised about Trump’s attendance this year as he repeatedly expressed his anger with NATO over what he described as its reluctance to help the United States with the war in Iran.

Speaking at a congressional hearing on Wednesday, Rubio touched upon Trump’s frustrations, saying his main irritation was some members not allowing the U.S. to use the military bases in those countries at a time of crisis.

Despite his disappointment with the alliance, Trump will still be attending the gathering, Rubio said.

“The United States is still in the NATO alliance, and we’ll be there in Turkey to talk about all these topics. The president himself will be attending the next NATO meeting of heads of state, where all these points will be made clear,” Rubio said.

Several NATO countries resisted supporting the U.S. military campaign against Iran by denying U.S. military planes use of their airspace or declining to send naval forces to help reopen the Strait of Hormuz for energy tankers.

Trump has repeatedly called NATO a “paper tiger” and threatened to withdraw from the 32-member transatlantic alliance in recent weeks.

AGENCIES

US kit, experts arrive at Kenya Ebola facility despite court order, protests

A court first ordered work on the Ebola facility to be suspended

NAIROBI: Around 20 flights carrying medical equipment and specialist staff have landed at a base in Kenya where the U.S. government is continuing to build an Ebola quarantine facility despite protests and Kenyan court orders blocking it, according to flight data and officials.

At least two people have been killed in protests in the central Kenyan town of Nanyuki, home to the Kenyan air force base where the U.S. military is building a 50-bed unit for Americans who might be exposed to the virus, which has infected hundreds in Democratic Republic of Congo and Uganda. A U.S. diplomatic



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

cable, part of which was seen by Reuters, said Kenya’s President William Ruto may have underestimated domestic opposition

to the plan, which has triggered criticism the U.S. is offloading the risk of caring for its own patients.

AGENCIES

AFTER BACKLASH

Trump admin drops ‘weaponization’ fund

WASHINGTON: The Trump administration is abandoning the president’s nearly \$1.8 billion “weaponization” fund, U.S. Acting Attorney General Todd Blanche told lawmakers on Tuesday, after a rare backlash from Republican senators.

But Blanche also told lawmakers that an agreement with Trump to bar future audits of his or his family’s past tax records will remain in place.

The fund emerged from a legal settlement between President Donald Trump and the Justice Department to resolve an unprecedented \$10 billion Trump lawsuit against the IRS over the alleged mishandling of his tax records.

The fund was dropped after furious Republican lawmakers said it might threaten the passage of a \$72 billion bill to fund Trump’s immigration crackdown. Blanche, Trump’s former personal attorney, has

held the top job at the Justice Department since early April, when Trump fired Pam Bondi as attorney general. A person familiar with the White House’s thinking said Blanche’s future hinged on his ability to address the concerns of Republican lawmakers about the fund.

The \$1.776 billion fund was meant to pay people who said they had been the subject of government abuse, and Blanche angered senators last month when he would not commit to excluding people who assaulted police officers during the January 6, 2021, Capitol riot.

White House officials spent much of Monday calling lawmakers to assure them there would be no payouts after the Republican revolt, said two sources familiar with the matter, speaking on the condition of anonymity.

AGENCIES

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Tender Notice
Name of Work and its location: 84-SRDEE-G-DLI-2026-27 Supply, installation, testing & commissioning of Retrofit Emission Control Devices (RECDs) on DG sets installed over Delhi Division.
Approx. cost of the works in: ₹ 29087919.00/-
Address of the Office: Sr. Div. Elect. Engineer/General, DRM Office, Delhi Division, Northern Railway, State Entry Road, New Delhi-110055
Earnest Money: Rs. 581800.00/-
Last Date & time of submission of tender: 24.06.2026, 16.00 Hrs.
Opening of tender: 24.06.2026, 16.00 Hrs.
Website & notice board: www.ireps.gov.in & Sr. Divl. Elect. Engineer/General, New Delhi 1877/2026
Serving Customers With A Smile

UJVN Limited
H.O.: "UJJAWAL", Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephone: 0135-2763808, Fax: 0135- 2763508
CIN NO. U40101UR2001SGC025866, Website: www.ujvn.com
RO No. 473 Tender Notice Dated : 03/06/2026
Office of the Executive Engineer (Generation), Ramganga Power Station, Kalagarh (Pauri-Garhwal) invites sealed tenders from interested parties. Brief summary of tender is given below:
T.No.: 04/EE(Gen.)/Klg/2026-27, 05/EE(Gen.)/Klg/2026-27, 06/EE(Gen.)/Klg/2026-27 & 07/EE(Gen.)/Klg/2026-27
Name of work/Supply: 1-Repairing, cleaning, painting of 66 MW Generator, Main exciter, PMG and 11KV bus duct of Unit No. 1 & 2.
2-Supply & fixing of LT cables and CCL of Rotor of Unit No. 1 & 2.
3- Detailed assessment by diagnostics & Engineering analysis for incipient fault prediction (Residual Life Assessment Tests) of Transformers.
4-Supply & Installation of various Relays.
Estimated cost - 1- Rs. 17,04,000.00 (GST extra), 2- Rs. 19,90,000.00 (GST extra), 3- Rs. 12,12,000.00 (GST extra) & 4- Rs. 06,07,010.00 (GST extra)
Date of Availability of bid document on website : 04.06.2026
Last date for submission of tender : 25.06.2026 up to 16:00 Hrs
For fuller & further details, kindly visit our website. The tender documents can be downloaded from the Nigam's website "www.ujvn.com"
Executive Engineer (Gen.)
"Avoid wasteful use of Electricity"

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-Tendering Tender Notice
Divisional Railway Manager (Works) N.C. Railway, Jhansi for and behalf of President of India invites sealed "Open Tender" through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.
E-Tender No. : JHS-ENGG-N-2026-135 | Approx Cost : 33112521.70
Description of work : Pre during, and post BCM works for deep screening, of ballast in points and crossing and plain track and De-Stressing in the jurisdiction of Sr.DEN/N/JHS
Earnest Money. : 662300.00 | Date of closing Tender. : 25.06.2026 at 15:00 hrs.
Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter : 12 Months.
•Tender online can be submitted up to 15:00 hrs on 25.06.2026 •For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in 1256/26 (AS)
North central railways | www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in | CPONCR

M.P. STATE AGRICULTURAL MARKETING BOARD
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER
26- Arera Hills, Jail Road, Bhopal
No./Const./BN/IND/26-27/07 Bhopal, Dated : 03.06.2026
Online Percentage Rate E-Tenders are invited from Contractors registered with the Office of the Engineer in Chief, M.P. Public Works Department, Government of Madhya Pradesh (Centralized Registration Cell) for Various Construction work at Additional Yard of Krishi Upaj Mandi samiti Narsinghpur Distt. Narsinghpur: Tender Number : 2026 MPSAM 512423 (PAC amount Rs. 985.60 Lakh) Construction of Compound wall, Drain Covered auction Platform (80x30) 2 Nos. and CC road work. Tender Number : 2026 MPSAM 512424 (PAC amount Rs. 165.42 Lakh) Construction of Gate and Check post 2 Nos., Water tank 4 Nos, Public toilet, Tube well with pipe line, laying of pipe line, Farmer rest shed and Canteen. Tender Number : 2026 MPSAM 512425 (PAC amount Rs. 100.13 Lakh) External Electrification with Transformer and High mast. The following works Tender to be received online up to 17:00 on 27.06.2026. Technical bid documents with EMD & Financial Offer to be received online only as per Detailed NIT. The tender documents can be obtained online on the http://mptenders.gov.in as per the Notice Published on the above Portal and detailed information can also be seen on website www.mpmandiboard.gov.in
Note : Any corrigendum in this NIT, if required, shall be displayed only in our above portal regarding any matter included in this NIT or otherwise. Other details of Construction/ Development works and locations & key dates can also be seen on our website www.mpmandiboard.gov.in
EXECUTIVE ENGINEER (PROJECT CELL)
M.P. Madhyam/126174/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED
See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person Chhotu @ Honey S/o Raju R/o Vegabond, Delhi (Foot Path Marina Hotel, Connaught Place, New Delhi) has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 36/2025 U/s 309/309(6)/3(5) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, P.S. Nabi Karim, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Chhotu @ Honey cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Chhotu @ Honey has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Chhotu @ Honey of case FIR No. 36/2025 U/s 309/309(6)/3(5) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, P.S. Nabi Karim, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 17.07.2026.
By Order
Dr. Rajkumar Singh
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05
Central District, Room No. 241
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi
DP/7042/CD/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C.
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Vikas Nakka, S/o Sh. Dara Singh, R/o H.No. S-180, Mangol Puri, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case E-FIR No. 7940/2016, U/s 411/487 IPC, P.S. Paschim Vihar West, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said Vikas Nakka cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Vikas Nakka has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said Vikas Nakka accused of E-FIR No. 7940/2016, U/s 411/487 IPC, P.S. Paschim Vihar West, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 10.07.2026.
By Order - Sh. Ankit Karan Singh
Metropolitan Magistrate-08, West
Room No. 30, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi
DP/7242/OD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
(See Section 82 Cr.PC)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Dinesh Kumar, S/o Suresh Chand R/o Flat No.503, Meshi Apartment Rohini, Sector-9, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No.700/14 u/s 186/353/341/34 IPC, P.S. North Rohini, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Dinesh Kumar cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Dinesh Kumar has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Dinesh Kumar of FIR No.700/14 u/s 186/353/341/34 IPC, P.S. North Rohini, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 27.07.2026.
By Order,
Ms. Ebbani Aggarwal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
Room No.107, Rohini Court, Delhi
DP/7092/RD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused Rashid @Chhota S/o Md. Farooq R/o K-301, Sunder Nagri, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No. 1259/2014 U/s 392/34 IPC, PS Nand Nagri, Delhi and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused Rashid @ Chhota cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Rashid @Chhota has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that Rashid @ Chhota in FIR No. 1259/2014 U/s 392/34 IPC, PS Nand Nagri, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 29.07.2026.
By order
Ms. Deepakshi Rana
Judicial Magistrate First Class
Court No. 19, Shahdara
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi
DP/7377/NE/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C.
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person Isioma S/o Etuokwu R/o H.No. 20, Near Jeet Property, Chander Vihar, Nihal Vihar, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence FIR No.1131/2024 u/s14/14C F. Act at P.S. Nihal Vihar, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said Isioma cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Isioma has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding u/s 82 Cr.P.C. has been initiated in the case. Proclamation is hereby made that the said Isioma accused of FIR No.1131/2024 u/s14/14C F. Act at P.S. Nihal Vihar, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on 08.07.2026.
By Order: Ms. Komal Garg,
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03,
West Distt., Court No. 292,
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi.
DP/7231/OD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Vikash Singh, S/o: Krishan Pal Singh, R/o: Flat No. 1619, Modern Apartment, Sector-15, Rohini, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 885/2007, U/s 406/408/420/467/468 IPC, P.S.: Nand Nagri, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Vikash Singh cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Vikash Singh has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said Vikash Singh accused of case FIR No. 885/2007, U/s 406/408/420/467/468 IPC, P.S.: Nand Nagri, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 04.07.2026.
By Order
Ms. Deepakshi Rana
Judicial Magistrate First Class - 03
Court No. 19, Karkardooma Court, Delhi
DP/7380/NE/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C.
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Simran, W/o Neeraj, R/o A-4/428, Sultanpuri, C-Block, North West, Delhi-86 has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 434/2020, U/s 354/354B/363/34 IPC & 8 POCSO Act, P.S. Laxmi Nagar, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said Deepanshu cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Simran has absconded (or is concealing herself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said Simran accused of FIR No. 434/2020, U/s 354/354B/363/34 IPC & 8 POCSO Act, P.S. Laxmi Nagar, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 06.07.2026.
By Order - Sh. Rakesh Kumar Rampuri
Additional Sessions Judge/SC POCSO Act
East District, Karkardooma Courts, Delhi
DP/7370/ED/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr P.C./ 84 BNSS
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person, namely, Nasruddin @ Nazir S/o Shaikh Nizamuddin R/o Vegabond Cd Park, Jahangir Puri, Delhi, Permanent Add.: Vill- Sutahata, Distt. Midnapore, West Bengal, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No.: 21/2026, U/s: 457/380/411/34 IPC, registered at P.S.: Jahangir Puri, Delhi, and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused person, Nasruddin @ Nazir, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person, Nasruddin @ Nazir, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said, accused person, Nasruddin @ Nazir, FIR No.: 21/2026, U/s: 457/380/411/34 IPC, registered at P.S.: Jahangir Puri, Delhi, is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 30.07.2026.
By Order
Sh. Sahil Gupta
Judicial Magistrate First Class
Room No. 06, Rohini Court, Delhi
DP/7357/NW/2026 (Court Matter)

HOLDINGS STAND STEADY AT 880.52 TONNES

No gold sold, clarifies Reserve Bank

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: On Wednesday, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) snubbed media reports which claimed the central bank had sold part of its gold reserves. They made it clear that their gold holdings have not changed and asked people to stick to official information from the RBI.

In a statement, the RBI stated its gold stock remains steady at 880.52 tonnes. Details about their gold stash are always available in their Monthly Bulletin, too. This clarification followed recent scrutiny over India's foreign exchange reserves.

There has been a notable bump in the value of India's gold holdings over the past year. As per the RBI's numbers - as of April 24, India's total forex reserves came in at US\$698.49 billion, which is down slightly from US\$703.31 billion the previous week.

Foreign Currency Assets (FCA), which form the large



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

est component of the reserves, were valued at US\$554.62 billion. Gold reserves were valued at US\$120.24 billion, while Special Drawing Rights (SDRs) and the Reserve Tranche Position with the International Monetary Fund (IMF) stood at US\$18.77 billion and US\$4.86 billion, respectively.

The central bank's clarification is important as fluctuations in the value of gold reserves are often confused

with changes in the quantity of gold held. India's gold reserves have risen sharply from around US\$ 81.82 billion in May 2025 to more than US\$ 120 billion by April this year.

However, the RBI said the rise is because of gains in international gold prices and not due to any sale or purchase that changed the physical stock of gold.

Global gold prices have surged in recent months as

CLOSER LOOK

- » The central bank's clarification is important as fluctuations in the value of gold reserves are often confused with changes in the quantity of gold held
- » India's gold reserves have risen sharply from around US\$ 81.82 billion in May 2025 to more than US\$ 120 billion by April this year
- » As per the RBI data, India has gradually increased its gold holdings over the last ten years to spread risk

geopolitical tensions, economic uncertainty and strong demand for safe-haven assets have gripped the markets. Even if the amount of gold has not changed, the value of gold held by central banks around the world has increased dramatically.

Gold plays a crucial role in a nation's foreign exchange reserves, along with foreign currency assets, SDRs, and the IMF reserve tranche posi-

tion. Gold shields economies from inflation and financial upheaval. Further, it becomes super valuable during global economic turmoil.

As per data provided by the Reserve Bank of India, India has gradually increased its gold holdings over the last ten years to spread risk. Even though foreign currency assets still make up most of the country's reserves, gold has become more significant. This is thanks to both new purchases and rising global prices for bullion.

RBI mentioned that foreign exchange reserves can fluctuate due to changing exchange rates and gold prices, not just the central bank's market activities.

India's reserves are still quite high, around US\$700 billion. This places the country among the top worldwide for holding foreign exchange reserves. These reserves act as a vital cushion against economic shocks, boost confidence in the rupee, and help the nation cover its import costs and other debt obligations.

Sensex falls over 300 points

Stock markets dragged by IT firms, spike in oil prices

OUR CORRESPONDENT

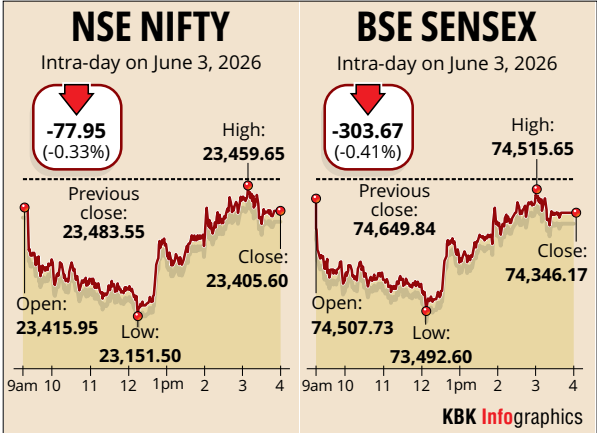
MUMBAI: Benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty closed lower on Wednesday after a day's breather, dragged by heavy selling in IT stocks, a fresh spike in crude oil prices and persistent foreign fund outflows.

The 30-share BSE Sensex dropped 303.67 points, or 0.41 per cent, to settle at 74,346.17. During the day, it tanked 1,157.24 points, or 1.55 per cent, to 73,492.60.

The 50-share NSE Nifty declined 77.95 points, or 0.33 per cent to end at 23,405.60. Benchmark indices had snapped a four-day falling streak to close nearly half a per cent higher in the previous session on Tuesday.

Among 30 Sensex firms, Tata Consultancy Services tumbled 8.43 per cent, followed by Tech Mahindra (6.23 per cent), HCL Tech (5.25 per cent) and Infosys (3.82 per cent). ITC, Eternal, Larsen & Toubro and Bajaj Finance were also among the laggards.

InterGlobe Aviation, State Bank of India, ICICI Bank and



Trent were among the gainers from the blue-chip pack.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, jumped 3 per cent to USD 98.92 per barrel. Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth Rs 8,362.92 crore on Tuesday, according to exchange data.

Rupee falls 40 paise

Meanwhile, the rupee depreciated 40 paise to close at 95.76 against the US dollar on Wednesday, after the US Trade Representative proposed a 12.5 per cent additional duties on

Indian imports, citing labour violations.

Forex traders said strong dollar demand, surging crude oil prices, geopolitical tensions, and relentless foreign capital outflows dented investor sentiment further.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.43 against the US dollar, then touched an intra-day low of 95.80 and finally ended the session at 95.76, down 40 paise from its previous close.

RBI MPC meet begins

Policy announcement on Friday

MUMBAI: The high-powered Monetary Policy Committee, headed by RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra, on Wednesday started its three-day brainstorming amid expectations that the central bank may leave the key policy rate unchanged at 5.25 per cent as the West Asia conflict poses challenges to inflation as well as economic growth.

After three days of deliberations, the six-member MPC will announce the decision on June 5. With surging energy prices, continuing supply chain woes and a depreciating rupee, primarily driven by external challenges, some experts are of the view that the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) may raise its inflation forecast and lower its GDP growth estimate.

In April, the Reserve Bank had kept its key policy rate unchanged, adopting a cautious wait-and-watch stance as policymakers assessed the fallout from the West Asia conflict

Some experts say the RBI may raise its inflation forecast and lower its GDP growth estimate

on energy supplies, inflation and growth.

A report from private-sector lender Yes Bank said that policy challenges remain magnified, even as the war situation improves, yet remain unresolved, thereby keeping the economy open to supply shocks. The pass-through from the WPI to retail inflation has just begun, in the form of increases in pump-head petrol and diesel prices, alongside increases in commercial LPG prices, it said. Also, manufacturing and farm input costs have risen sharply, and manufacturers have indicated a willingness to pass the impact onto the retail side.

Cabinet approves Rs 10K cr jet fuel 'stabilisation' fund

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Union Cabinet, chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, has approved a one-time budgetary support of up to Rs 10,000 crore to help stabilise Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF) prices for Scheduled Indian Airlines amid unprecedented volatility in global fuel markets triggered by the ongoing West Asia crisis.

Beginning with a government directive, funds flow to Oil Marketing Companies via the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas in the form of zero-interest advances. Stability in domestic and global flight operations remains the central focus, as price swings in aviation turbine fuel are absorbed by this mechanism.

Under the approved mechanism, OMCs will be compensated whenever international ATF prices exceed a benchmark level. Once prices moderate, the differential amount will be recovered from OMCs and returned to the Consolidated Fund of India through a structured recovery and true-up process.

Every qualified Indian airline may join the program, operating at home or abroad. For a period reaching thirty-six months, those involved obtain aviation turbine fuel solely through Oil Marketing Companies. A set rate applies

throughout, shielding against abrupt increases in fuel costs. This structure remains active only if suppliers commit without exception. Duration limits stand firm regardless of market shifts. Stability forms the core focus during implementation.

A committee tasked with oversight will include members from the Ministry of Civil Aviation, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, along with officials from the Department of Expenditure. Oversight duties cover claim verification, implementation tracking, audit processes, followed by reconciliation work. Each phase unfolds under structured review, ensuring alignment across agencies involved. Procedures remain consistent, guided by assigned responsibilities within the group. A shift in policy aims to strengthen airline finances by reducing swings in ticket prices. Stability in fares may help preserve jobs tied to aviation networks. Connectivity to smaller urban centres should remain intact under the plan. For a period of three years, the assistance arrangement stays active, continuing unless ended earlier through yearly assessments or once full repayment occurs. It persists until either the complete sum has been reclaimed or reassessment determines continuation unnecessary.

'JUST 1% STICKING POINTS UNDER DISCUSSION'

Indo-US trade deal 'almost done', says Gor

MUMBAI: Suggesting that India-United States trade deal was 99 per cent complete, US Ambassador Sergio Gor said on Wednesday both sides were trying to resolve the remaining "1 per cent" sticking points and expected the long-awaited pact to be inked within the next several weeks.

The US Ambassador to India, who also serves as Special Envoy to South and Central Asia, said America has lower tariffs for India than any of its neighbours and insisted Washington values its relationship with New Delhi.

Speaking at Citi's 2026 India Conference in Mumbai, the Ambassador noted that when US President Donald Trump was not in office from January 2021 to January 2025 after his first term, Prime Minister Narendra Modi still stayed in touch with him during those four years, highlighting their deep personal bond.

"Your prime minister

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Ambassador Gor said the US has lower tariffs for India than any of its neighbours
- » He insisted Washington values its relationship with New Delhi

normally never criticises the president. He (PM Modi) has stayed in touch during those four years when the president (Trump) was out (of office). And that's something that the president remembers," Gor told the gathering.

Further highlighting the friendship between the two leaders, he said, "It is easy to see today (that) some leaders, some leaders from the Europe that show up to the Oval Office ...everyone of them wants to be president's best friend. But it matters when you are down on who your true friend is. That's what the president appreciates

about Prime Minister Modi."

The 39-year-old Ambassador said a US team is currently in India to negotiate the bilateral trade pact.

Top negotiators from India and the US on Tuesday began a three-day round of talks in New Delhi to finalise the details of the proposed interim trade agreement. The framework for the pact was finalised in February. The US team is led by its chief negotiator Brendan Lynch, while India's chief negotiator is Darpan Jain, an additional secretary in the Department of Commerce.

"And so that is something that this relationship is valued, that the (US) trade team that is right now negotiating on that. Once that trade deal is finalised...the interim trade deal was there in place. It is that 1 per cent that we are trying to get across the finish line. So the leaders can have a signing and put that in stone and in law," Gor said at the conference.

Andhra explores AI & quantum tech ties with Russia's Sberbank

MOSCOW: As part of Andhra Pradesh's efforts to strengthen global technology partnerships and position itself as a leading innovation hub, Andhra Pradesh IT, Electronics and Education Minister Nara Lokesh held discussions with Albert Yefimov, Senior Vice President of Sberbank, during his visit to Russia.

The meeting focused on emerging technologies and opportunities for collaboration in areas such as artificial intelligence, digital public infrastructure, cybersecurity, fintech, quantum computing

and workforce development. Sberbank officials presented an overview of the institution's technology ecosystem, including its GigaChat large language model, AI research programmes and digital solutions deployed across banking and citizen-facing services.

Lokesh highlighted Andhra Pradesh's ambition to emerge as a major AI and technology destination and expressed interest in adopting global best practices to accelerate the state's digital transformation initiatives. The discussions explored how advanced technologies



could be leveraged to improve governance, public service delivery and economic growth.

Artificial intelligence applications in healthcare also featured prominently in the talks.

Both sides exchanged views on the use of AI for early disease detection, diagnostics, medical research, hospital management and expanding access to healthcare services at scale.

The meeting further examined developments in quantum computing and advanced research ecosystems. Lokesh discussed the possibility of future collaboration involving research institutions, technology companies and innovation centres to support emerging technology development in Andhra Pradesh.

Technology education and

workforce readiness were also key areas of discussion. The two sides shared perspectives on coding education, AI skill development and industry-oriented training programmes aimed at preparing young professionals for the rapidly evolving digital economy.

In addition, the discussions covered broader opportunities to enhance economic cooperation between India and Russia, including strengthening business linkages, supporting exporters and using technology to improve cross-border trade ecosystems.

'Dark Pattern' practices: CCPA slaps fines on PhysicsWallah and McAfee

NEW DELHI: The Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) has penalised edtech firm PhysicsWallah and cybersecurity company McAfee Software India for deploying deceptive interface designs -- commonly known as "dark patterns" -- that manipulated users into actions they did not intend to take.

PhysicsWallah has been fined Rs 5 lakh, while McAfee has been handed a Rs 1 lakh penalty. Both companies have been directed to remove such practices from their platforms immediately, the regulator said.

Dark patterns are user interface design tricks that nudge or coerce consumers into making unintended purchases, signing up for subscriptions, or surrendering personal data. The CCPA notified the Guidelines for Prevention and Regulation of Dark Patterns in November 2023, identifying 13 such practices as unfair trade.

India's overall hiring dips 4% in May; diversity recruitment surges: Report

'Overall white-collar hiring dropped 6% month-on-month'

MUMBAI: India's white-collar hiring activity moderated in May 2026, by declining 4 per cent year-on-year, despite a surge in diversity hiring, according to a report released on Wednesday.

The overall white-collar hiring dropped 6 per cent month-on-month, indicating continued employer caution amid evolving market conditions, according to the latest foundit Insights Tracker (fit) report. However, diversity hiring increased 21 per cent during the same period. Slowing recruitment across multiple sectors like import and export (-23 per cent), logistics and transportation (-18 per cent), retail (-8 per cent), and BFSI (-8 per cent) affected the year-on-year hiring trend, it added.

Sectors like travel and tourism (26 per cent), automotive (12 per cent), healthcare and pharmaceuticals (11 per cent), and real estate (11 per cent) witnessed robust YoY hiring momentum in May.

The foundit Insights Tracker (fit) report is a comprehensive



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

monthly analysis of 7,39,188 online job posting activity conducted by foundit.in, a leading job search platform. According to the report, diversity hiring witnessed a double-digit growth in May, reflecting employer commitment to inclusive workforce strategies even as overall recruitment activity remained selective.

Women accounted for 56 per cent of all diversity-focused recruitment, while PwD (People with Disabilities) representation tripled over two years, growing to 12 per cent. At the same time, D&I (diversity and inclusion) hiring, which

includes LGBTQIA+ and neurodiverse talent, expanded to nearly a third of all diversity recruitments, the report added. "While overall hiring has grown more selective, organisations continue to invest in talent areas that support long-term business resilience," foundit CEO Tarun Sinha said.

The sustained momentum in diversity hiring reflects a structural shift in how India Inc is approaching inclusion - less as a compliance requirement and more as a capability strategy, he stated.

"The expansion into leadership roles, technology

INSIGHT

- » Slowing recruitment across multiple sectors like import and export (-23%), logistics and transportation (-18%), retail (-8%), and BFSI (-8%) affected the YoY hiring trend
- » Travel & tourism (26%), automotive (12%), healthcare & pharma (11%), and real estate (11%) witnessed robust YoY hiring momentum in May

functions, and previously underrepresented groups such as PwD signals a more integrated and mature approach to building future-ready workforces," Sinha added.

According to the report, the IT-Software and Services sector led diversity hiring at 25 per cent. LGBTQIA+ and neurodiverse talent comprised up to 40 per cent of the total diversity hiring in the sector.

The BFSI sector recorded the highest women representation at 62 per cent of its diversity hiring, followed by FMCG (61 per cent) and Healthcare (60 per cent).

India's economy resilient amid geopolitical uncertainties: RBI Deputy Gov

MUMBAI: India's economic activity has demonstrated resilience, fuelled by the growth of the industrial and services sectors, broad-based demand, and improving corporate performance, despite geopolitical uncertainties, according to Reserve Bank Deputy Governor Swaminathan J.

In a speech at the School of International and Public Affairs (SIPA), Columbia University, on Monday, the deputy governor also said inflation is within the RBI's tolerance band, and external vulnerabilities remain manageable.

"We meet at a time when the global policy conversation is again crowded with large themes: geopolitics, climate change, artificial intelligence, technological disruption and the reordering of supply chains," he said.

Against that backdrop, Swaminathan said, banking resilience may seem like a quieter subject.

Mumbai: Adani, JSW consortium win bids to revamp 3 clusters

MUMBAI: The Maharashtra Housing and Area Development Authority (MHADA) has finalised developers for the cluster redevelopment of three prime Mumbai localities—Adarsh Nagar in Worli, Bandra Reclamation and Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel (SVP) Nagar in Andheri West.

According to media reports, Adani Properties Pvt Ltd emerged as the "highest bidder for the Adarsh Nagar and Bandra Reclamation projects, while a consortium led by JSW Steel secured the SVP Nagar redevelopment project".

MHADA had floated bids for the redevelopment of the three clusters, spanning a combined 206.49 acres, on April 8 and opened technical submissions on May 20. The authority announced the successful bidders on Tuesday. The JSW-led consortium includes Hanura Realty, a subsidiary of JSW Steel, along with Chandak Realtors, Premsagar Infra Realty and Vantier Realty.

The bids will now be placed before a high-powered com-

The 3 prime clusters are Adarsh Nagar, Bandra Reclamation and SVP Nagar

mittee constituted for the projects. Following the committee's approval, the proposals will be forwarded to the Maharashtra government for final clearance.

Among the three projects, Bandra Reclamation is the largest at 98.27 acres, followed by SVP Nagar at 73.89 acres and Adarsh Nagar at 34.33 acres.

The redevelopment will be undertaken through the Construction and Development Agency (C&DA) model. Eligible residents will receive transit rent during the redevelopment period and a corpus fund towards maintenance expenses. Meanwhile, resident groups and housing societies from the three localities are awaiting the June 9 hearing of their petition before the Bombay High Court challenging MHADA's cluster redevelopment tender process.

Crown in Diana’s sights

Shnaider stuns Sabalenka to make semis, Chwalinska follows suit

PARIS: Top-ranked Aryna Sabalenka wasted a lead of a set and two breaks to lose 3-6, 7-5, 6-0 to Diana Shnaider in the French Open quarterfinals on Wednesday.

The four-time Major winner led 4-1 in the second set and was two points from victory when serving for the match at 5-4 before completely collapsing against a player appearing in her first Grand Slam quarterfinal.

“Well, honestly I am speechless. Super happy,” Shnaider said. “I feel like I was trying to focus point by point. Not thinking about the score. She is the world No. 1, so I just trying to do my best. I just had to fight for every point.”



Diana Shnaider dispatched Aryna Sabalenka 3-6 7-5 6-0 in their quarterfinal; Maja Chwalinska upset Anna Kalinskaya



AP

Sabalenka stood still and screamed loudly after losing a point to fall 0-30 down in the sixth game of the decider and, although she saved two match points at 0-40 down, she lost the match when she sent a shot into the net. In all, she lost 12 of the last 13 games.

Earlier, Wednesday, Maja Chwalinska extended her remarkable run by beating No. 22-seeded Anna Kalinskaya 7-6 (3), 6-3.

For Sabalenka, her struggles were reminiscent of last year's final against Coco Gauff, when she remonstrated loudly,

shouting to herself and glaring at her team box before losing to the American.

Sabalenka had already looked agitated when serving for the first set but still looked in control as she served for the match in the second, holding a 30-15 lead.

But Shnaider, who was already on her best run at a major, broke Sabalenka before taking complete control.

Mensik stands tall

Less than a week ago, Jakub Mensik was pushed away from the court in a wheelchair after

2

Chwalinska becomes only second qualifier in Open era to reach Roland Garros semis

collapsing to the clay with cramps.

Now the 20-year-old Czech player is in the French Open semifinals.

The 6-foot-5 Mensik used his attacking game to end the run of Brazil's Joao Fonseca with a 6-4, 6-3, 7-6 (3) victory in the quarterfinals Tuesday.

It was Mensik's most convincing performance so far at Roland Garros after struggling physically in the heat wave during the opening week.

After Mensik edged Mariano Navone in a fifth-set tiebreaker in the second round, he fell to the clay after match

point and required medical attention on the court after Navone went over to check on him. Mensik was eventually helped up and limped off the court, then was pushed away in a wheelchair.

Two days later, Mensik still appeared weak when he dropped the opening set 6-0 to Alex de Minaur. But then he won three straight sets. “After the cramps and super dehydrations, I needed to put as much fluids as I could inside of me,” Mensik said after beating De Minaur.

AGENCIES

NORWAY CHESS

Pragg does a historic double over Carslen; Gukesh’s hopes end

OSLO: Young Indian Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa dealt another stunning blow to hometown hero and world No. 1 Magnus Carslen, defeating the Norwegian in a classical game for the second time at Norway Chess 2026 and boosting his bid to become the first Indian champion of the prestigious event.



R Praggnanandhaa shakes hand with Magnus Carlsen

NORWAY CHESS

World champion D. Gukesh's title hopes ended after another heavy Round 8 defeat to French Grandmaster Alireza Firouzja, leaving him bottom of the table on eight points and still unable to halt a worrying run of form since his 2024 world title triumph.

In a remarkable achievement in the elite double round-robin event, Praggnanandhaa became the only player to beat Carslen twice in classical games this year, underlining his growing stature.

With two rounds still to play, the win pushed 20-year-old Praggnanandhaa up to third place on 12 points, with Alireza second on 13 and American GM Wesley So still leading on 14 points after an Armageddon tie-break victory over Germany's Vincent Keymer. Carslen's poor run of form continued, leaving his bid for an eighth Norway Chess title all but over. He sits on

1

Praggnanandhaa became the only player to beat Carslen twice in classical games this year

just nine points, and even two classical wins is unlikely to be enough to pull him back into contention.

Carslen has endured an uncharacteristically turbulent

campaign, suffering a third defeat overall at the hands of Praggnanandhaa, who had also beaten him once in the 2024 edition of the tournament and has now emerged as one of the strongest challengers to his long-standing dominance.

“It's more important for the tournament that I get this win than thinking that it's Magnus. Of course, it's great to do it against Magnus, but I think winning any game at this stage is good,” said Praggnanandhaa, who had the black pieces, after the match.

Women had two decisive classical games and one Armageddon finish in Round 8, with Bibisara Assaubayeva inching closer to title.

AGENCIES

ENGLAND TAKE SERIES

Despite Eng loss, India clear on T20 WC XI



India open campaign against arch-rivals Pakistan on June 14

PTI

TAUNTON: Skipper Harmanpreet Kaur said India will use the two warm-up matches ahead of the Women's T20 World Cup to test a few more combinations and give opportunities to players such as Radha Yadav and Bharti Fulmali.

India arrived in England hoping to end their long wait for a maiden Women's T20 World Cup title. However, their build-up to the ICC showpiece suffered a setback after hosts England came from behind to clinch the three-match T20I series 2-1. After registering a 38-run victory in the opener, India slipped to a 26-run defeat before losing the decider by six wickets on Tuesday.

“I feel we are pretty much clear, like what our XI is going to be going forward. I think we are pretty much clear and still we have two more games, practice games before the World Cup where we can still think about the other combinations,” she said after the loss.

“Like Radha is there. She did really well in WPL and she also feels ready. And apart from her, Bharti Fulmali is also there. She is a middle-order batter. She also batted really well. I think still we have two very good players who are sitting out and hopefully we will give

“

I feel we are pretty much clear, like what our XI is going to be going forward

Harmanpreet Kaur

them a fair chance in the practice games where we can see how they go about,” Harmanpreet added.

India have already experimented with their batting order following the return of Yastika Bhatia from a lengthy injury layoff. Yastika has batted at No. 3 throughout the England series, resulting in Jemimah Rodrigues, who has traditionally excelled in that position, moving down to No. 4. Harmanpreet, meanwhile, has dropped from her customary No. 4 slot to No. 5.

With the openers struggling for consistency during the series against England and Richa Ghosh also not able to make a significant impact in the lower middle-order, the doors could open for Fulmali, whose only appearance on the tour came in the opening match.

AGENCIES

India to play biggest-ever bilateral series in New Zealand

AUCKLAND: India will tour New Zealand for a marathon all-format series from October 22 to December 1 this year, featuring an unprecedented 10 white-ball games in what would be the biggest men's bilateral cricket series ever held in this country.

India will take on the Black Caps in five T20Is, as many ODIs and two Tests across five major centres. The 12 matches would be the highest ever featuring a touring side in New Zealand's history.

The series would be a major landmark as the two countries celebrate 100 years of sporting ties. The 40-day tour will begin with the opening T20I in Christchurch on October 22.

The T20I series will be followed by the ODI leg, which will start at Eden Park in Auckland on November 4.

The Test series will commence at the Cello Basin Reserve in Wellington from November 19 to 23, while the second and final Test will be played at Hagley Oval in Christchurch from November 27 to December 1. The series will mark India's first Test tour since the 2019-20.

AGENCIES

Ayush storms into Indonesia last-16; Satwik-Chirag retire hurt

JAKARTA: Young Indian shuttler Ayush Shetty came from behind to pull off a dramatic victory and advance to the pre-quarterfinals, while star men's doubles pair Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty were forced to retire midway through their opening-round match at the Indonesia Open here on Wednesday.

Shetty, ranked 20th, battled for 66 minutes before registering an 8-21, 22-20, 21-15 win over World No. 15 Hong Yang Weng of China in the opening round of the Super 1000 tournament.

After being outplayed in the first game, the 21-year-old Indian produced a spirited fightback, overturning an 11-15 deficit in the second game with a series of superb rallies to force a decider.

The Badminton Asia Championships silver medalist looked in complete control in the third game as he sealed his place in the second round, where he will face Hong Kong's Lee Cheuk Yiu.

Satwik and Chirag, meanwhile, were forced to retire just seven minutes into their opening men's doubles match after a shoulder problem troubled the former.

Fresh from ending their



Ayush Shetty registered a 8-21 22-20 21-15 win

FILE

Satwik and Chirag, meanwhile, were forced to retire just seven minutes into their opening men's doubles match after a shoulder problem troubled the former

two-year title drought with a triumph at the Singapore Open last week, the Indian duo were trailing 6-11 against Malaysia's Kang Khai Xing and Aaron Tai when Satwik was seen pointing

to his right shoulder, prompting the match to be called off.

In men's singles, HS Prannoy suffered a first-round exit after losing to Ireland's Nhat Nguyen in a hard-fought three-game encounter.

After dropping the opening game 17-21, Prannoy bounced back to take the second 21-16 but failed to maintain the momentum, going down 19-21 in the decider. In mixed doubles, World No. 41 pair Rohan Kapoor and Ruthvika Gadde progressed to the second round with a comfortable 21-14, 21-14 victory over Chinese Taipei's Po-Hsuan Yang and Ling Fang Hu.

AGENCIES

England seek a fresh start at Lord's vs NZ as Ashes backlash lingers

LONDON: The past is fiercely protected at Lord's Cricket Ground. The Long Room, the slope of the field, the bell before play, dress codes and honors boards.

But inside this normally comforting time capsule, England will try to escape its recent past when it begins its first home test of the year against New Zealand on Thursday.

An occasion that should herald a fresh start is enveloped by a stench of dissatisfaction lingering from England's humiliating tour to Australia.

A team that was groomed for two years to end Australia's grip on the Ashes was crushed in 11 days before Christmas; tied for the quickest Ashes series defeat in 104 years. England's slack preparation and wrong tactical approach were aggravated by reports of excessive drinking under relentless local media scrutiny.

None of the leadership group paid a price. Director of cricket Rob Key, coach Brendon McCullum and captain Ben Stokes survived a review of the Ashes tour. That didn't go down well with team supporters, and McCullum understood.

“You have got to handle a little bit of the backlash,” he



told the BBC.

Fixes since the Ashes include reimposing a curfew and hiring more backroom staff, including fielding coach Sarah Taylor, the wicketkeeping great and first woman to coach an England men's test team.

Nothing banishes a putrid odor like the sweet smell of success, and England can take heart from its response to a similarly dire state in 2022 when McCullum, a former New Zealand captain, took charge.

England had lost the Ashes 4-0 in Australia and lost to the West Indies 1-0 in the Caribbean, prompting Joe Root to quit as captain. New Zealand arrived and Bazball was launched; England scored 279, 299 and 296 in consecutive second innings to sweep the series.

Surya set to be removed as T20 skipper

MULLANPUR: Suryakumar Yadav is set to be removed as captain of the India T20 team and the all-powerful Apex Council might be informed of his status even before the squad for the UK tour is selected.

Shreyas Iyer and Tilak Varma have emerged as the top contenders to succeed Surya as the leader of the Indian T20 side.

It is expected that BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia will apprise the Apex Council about whether the national selection committee and head coach Gautam Gambhir are on the same page regarding Surya's removal.

It is clear that if Surya is removed from captaincy, he won't also remain in the side as a player after nearly 18 months of non performance.

“Surya is set to be removed from captaincy. The selectors wanted to wait till the end of IPL to see whether he can get back to form. Since he looked completely out of form and not just out of runs... a tough call needs to be taken,” a BCCI source said on Wednesday.

“The selectors would be dropping him from long list and had given an indication that Surya is now out of their scheme of things. Shreyas Iyer and Tilak Varma are contenders to become captain.”

AGENCIES

After 60 years of hurt, England turn to Tuchel to end World Cup drought

MANCHESTER: In a bid to end its decades-long wait to win a second World Cup, England have put their fate in the hands of a German.

It's fair to say the appointment of Thomas Tuchel was not universally well received.

“I'm sorry I have a German passport,” the serial-winning former Paris Saint-Germain, Chelsea and Bayern Munich coach quipped at his official unveiling in 2024.

He had woken that morning to some unflattering headlines in the British media.

The Daily Mail described it as a “dark day for England” and said the national team had gambled on a “GERMAN.”

The leader of the right-wing Reform Party Nigel Farage asked on X: “Why can't we have an English manager?”

Never mind that Tuchel



If Tuchel can end the wait, he would become a national treasure

FILE

was a Champions League winner who had lifted trophies in three different countries. Or the fact that England has gone down the foreign route before:

a Swedish coach in Sven-Goran Eriksson and an Italian in Fabio Capello. And in the days before Tuchel's appointment, there were rumors that

It's fair to say the appointment of Thomas Tuchel was not universally well received

Pep Guardiola was also a leading candidate.

Difficult decisions

Tuchel stunned some fans and players with his squad selection for the World Cup, leaving out big names including Phil Foden, Cole Palmer and Trent Alexander-Arnold.

It was evidence that he would not be swayed by public opinion, which has been a criticism of previous coaches.

“Everything I know about international football tells me that tournaments are won by teams, not individuals,” he said. “What we're trying to achieve in the summer can only be achieved as a team.”

Tuchel is the 14th coach tasked with the challenge of ending England's trophy drought, which now stretches to 60 years.

After Southgate's departure the English Football Association said it was looking for a candidate to “win a major tournament.” That might sound obvious, but even coaches who had won big prizes with club teams such as Bobby Robson, Terry Venables, Eriksson and Capello could not emulate that success with England.

Time will tell if Tuchel is portrayed as a hero or villain at the World Cup.

AGENCIES



LEGAL NOTICE BY RANVEER SINGH

FWICE WITHDRAWS NON-COOPERATION DIRECTIVE AGAINST RANVEER

The decision was taken after an intervention by the IMPPA, the PGI and CINTAA

The Federation of Western India Cine Employees (FWICE) on Wednesday said it withdrew the non-cooperative directive issued against Ranveer Singh over his exit from Farhan Akhtar's 'Don 3' after the 'Dhurandhar' star sent a legal notice to the organisation.

The decision was taken after an intervention by the Indian Motion Picture Producers' Association (IMPPA), the Producers Guild of India (PGI) and Cine & TV Artists' Association (CINTAA).

"We are taking back our non-cooperative directive from immediate effect after a request by IMPAA, the producers' guild and CINTAA. We have been told that we should all sit together with the producers' body and take an appropriate decision where neither the producers and directors nor the actor face any issues," FWICE president BN Tiwari told reporters here.

He added, "No one has won or lost in this matter. Our legal department will respond to his legal notice."

The non-cooperation directive against Singh was issued on May 25 and came after Akhtar and his producing partner Ritesh Sidhwani filed a complaint with the Indian Film and Television Directors' Association (IFTDA), which referred the issue to



'No one has won or lost in this matter. Our legal department will respond to his legal notice,' says FWICE president BN Tiwari

the FWICE for further intervention.

'Don 3', a reboot of the popular franchise, has reportedly been in development for three years and has yet to begin shooting. The producers have claimed that over Rs 45 crore had

already been spent on pre-production.

At the time, Singh's spokesperson issued a statement, saying the actor continues to hold 'deep respect and goodwill' for everyone associated with the film and the industry.

PTI

KALKI KOECHLIN TAKES MOTHERHOOD CENTRE STAGE

Aadyam Theatre is presenting its third production for this year, 'Belly of the Beast'

JAI TALWAR

Aadyam Theatre is presenting its third production for this year, 'Belly of the Beast' adapted from Kalki Koечlin's book 'Elephant in the Womb'. The play is a modern-day myth that explores the emotional, psychological and transformative realities of motherhood through five interconnected stories.

Directed by acclaimed theatre-maker Sheena Khalid, the production features Kalki Koечlin along with Ketan Singh and other actors, combining shadow puppetry, live music and dark humour to explore the emotional and transformative realities of motherhood.

The play is a modern-day myth that explores the emotional, psychological and transformative realities of motherhood through five interconnected stories

The play follows five women at different stages of motherhood, from pregnancy and labour to postpartum life, raising young children and learning to let go. As their worlds shift, they find themselves transforming into mythical creatures, reflecting the emotional and physical intensity of their journeys. The play is inspired by lived experiences and testimonies, exploring motherhood in all its contradictions: beautiful and terrifying, exhausting and tender, deeply



personal yet universally resonant.

Created in collaboration with acclaimed puppeteer Anurupa Roy, the shadow work allows the mythical creatures to exist alongside the performers, while an original live score by Guy Hersberg is expected to deepen the emotional texture of the production.

Talking about shaping the production and playing an integral role as an actor, Kalki Koечlin said, "Pregnancy is tough, birth is gruesome and postpartum is hell, but more horrifying than all three is society's completely casual approach to one of the most epic experiences life has to offer. Only when you become a mother do you awaken to the intensity and wonder of it all, to the sheer strength of character required to create life and to transformations of mythic proportions that are unleashed upon mothers."

'Belly of the Beast' premieres at Kamani Auditorium, Delhi, on June 27 and June 28, before travelling to Jamshed Bhabha Theatre, NCPA, Mumbai on July 11 and July 12.

Robert dismisses claims he skipped gym for 'The Batman'

Hollywood star Robert Pattinson hit back at critics who claimed he didn't work out for his role as the Caped Crusader in 'The Batman', saying he trained twice a day and even in the early hours of the morning.

The British actor, who is set to reprise the role of Bruce Wayne aka The Batman in filmmaker Matt Reeves' 'The Batman: Part II', told 'GQ' magazine that the perception of him skipping the gym stemmed from a quip he made in an earlier interview.

"I worked out every f**king day. Even after that, I still look like I didn't work out. I worked out twice a day at, like, three o'clock in the morning. It's just because I said it in an interview (that exercise was uncool). I was trying to sound cool," Pattinson said.

The 40-year-old actor said he has since set up a home gym at his Beverly Hills residence to prepare for the upcoming sequel.

Pattinson, however, admitted he had yet to receive an official filming schedule, saying he only learned about the shoot's demands through his stunt coordinator. "I just heard from the stunt guy the other day. He said, 'Ooh, 11 weeks of nights. I'm like, 'Excuse me? No one's even sent me a schedule,'" he said.



Pattinson is set to reprise the role of Bruce Wayne aka The Batman in 'The Batman: Part II'

Reeves has lined up a star-studded cast for 'The Batman: Part II'.

In the sequel, Pattinson will be joined by Sebastian Stan, Scarlett Johansson, Brian Tyree Henry, Charles Dance and Sebastian Koch. The returning cast members include Jeffrey Wright, Andy Serkis and Colin Farrell. Actor Barry Keoghan is also believed to be returning as the Joker, reprising the cameo role he had in the first film. The film, which recently started production, is currently scheduled to be released in the US theatres on October 1, 2027.

PTI

Kriti Sanon addresses rumours surrounding 'Cocktail 2'



Kriti Sanon addressed the ongoing buzz around her upcoming film 'Cocktail 2', which also features Rashmika Mandanna and Shahid Kapoor. The project has been generating curiosity for months, with media speculation suggesting that Kriti and Rashmika might be seen playing a same-s*x couple in the romantic drama.

At the trailer launch of 'Cocktail 2' held on Tuesday, Kriti addressed the ongoing rumours surrounding the film and its characters. She pushed back against the speculation and said, "It is really sad because, as Dinesh Vijan said, do ladke hote hain toh bromance ho jata hai and do ladkiyaan hoti hain, toh somehow people don't want to believe they can be friends. Yaa toh inn mein rivalry hai, ya toh kuch aur chal raha hai."

Furthermore, director Homi Adajania clarified the speculation around 'Cocktail 2', explaining that the rumours are not based on the film's storyline. He said that Kriti and Rashmika share a friendly bond off-screen and often behave in an affectionate, playful manner. He added that he once hypothetically imagined a scenario where the story could revolve around them, with Shahid as a 'third wheel'.

AGENCIES

Media speculation suggests that Kriti and Rashmika might be seen playing a same-s*x couple in the romantic drama

PGI condemns cases of talents reneging their commitments

The Producers Guild of India called out growing instances of talent, directors and technicians reneging on their contracts with producers at the last minute.

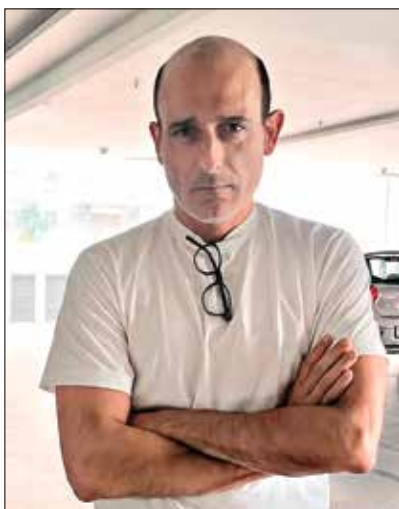
Though the letter didn't mention Ranveer Singh or Akshaye Khanna, who have been accused of dropping out of 'Don 3' and 'Drishyam 3', respectively, at the last minute, the PGI said they have received formal complaints from the film's producers 'Excel Entertainment Private Limited' and 'Panorama Studios International Limited'.

"No member of the industry should indulge in such behaviour that has, in these cases, led to substantial financial loss to our member producers as well as to other verticals in the industry. Such actions by any industry member have serious and far-reaching consequences and undermine the spirit of trust, professionalism and mutual respect on which the film industry is built," the guild said in a statement.

Ranveer Singh and Akshaye Khanna were accused of dropping out of 'Don 3' and 'Drishyam 3', at the last minute

The PGI's statement came on the day the Federation of Western India Cine Employees (FWICE) withdrew its non-cooperation directive against Singh over his exit from 'Don 3'.

The producers' body said such instances



lead to significant reputational damage, adverse impact on credibility and brand value of the films concerned and jeopardise the livelihoods of hundreds of technicians and crew members who depend on these projects.

"We would also like to state in no uncertain terms that the Guild always stands for a free and fair business environment without encouraging any encumbrances or disruptions to the process of content production. Any position to the contrary is not ethical and harms the collaborative spirit of our filmmaking community. We urge all parties to resolve their disputes amicably and we will strive to protect the fraternity's interests," the guild further stated.

PTI

Wanted to quit acting for a decade: Manoj Bajpayee

'I find a nice role & go back to work,' he says

When 'Satya' was released in 1998, Bhiku Mhatre became a cult figure and Manoj Bajpayee was suddenly thrust into the spotlight. What followed were acclaimed performances in films like 'Shool', 'Zubeidaa' and eventually 'Gangs of Wasseypur', cementing his place among India's finest actors. Known for his remarkable versatility and ability to breathe life into every character he portrays, Bajpayee has given audiences countless memorable performances. Yet behind the applause lies a personal cost. In a recent conversation with Ranveer Allahabadi on his podcast, the actor revealed that for nearly a decade, he has repeatedly contemplated walking away from acting altogether.

Explaining the reason behind these thoughts, he said, "Taking intense characters and performing them over the years makes you a very moody person. The mood swings are way too high. For the past ten years, I've had thoughts of quitting acting. But



then I find a nice role and go back to work."

According to the actor, the dilemma stems from his desire to preserve acting as a passion rather than allowing it to become a routine profession. "I don't want acting to become a mandatory job. I want to do it out of passion, not because I have responsibilities to fulfil at home or because it's my source of livelihood."

After years of immersing him-

self in emotionally draining roles, Bajpayee confessed that he is now yearning for something lighter. "Lately, I have been craving to do a commercial film. I want to be in an out-and-out slapstick comedy. Absolute nonsense. Dance to music. A film that requires no preparation. I just want to go on set without thinking too much about what I am playing and have a good time. I want to escape from all the things I have been doing."

AGENCIES



The actor is known for his remarkable versatility and ability to breathe life into every character he portrays



AROUND THE WORLD

- » Jaipuria Institute of Management advances faculty development agenda aligned with NEP 2020 and AI-enabled learning
- » IIT Madras research group calls for strategic push to create 2 million high-value 'eXtended Reality' jobs by 2030
- » NTA has issued admit cards for candidates whose CUET UG 2026 test was rescheduled. The affected candidates will now appear on June 6 and 7



BUZZER ROUND

Q) WHO IS KNOWN AS THE FATHER OF THE GREEN REVOLUTION IN INDIA?

Send us your replies to careersmp22@gmail.com. We shall publish the names of the first 3 correct entries in next week's edition

Answer to our May 28 edition question: 1992

Correct answers were sent by: **Pramod Sharma, Swarnava Mukherjee, Pallavi Ghosh**



NEWS & VIEWS

IIT Madras has developed an injectable hydrogel that could transform the treatment of fibrosis and other chronic degenerative conditions by replacing weeks of repeated medication with a single localised dose. This could drastically reduce the cost of treatment.

A joint study by IIT Gandhinagar and the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign (UIUC), US showed that herbal cigarettes, widely sold in India and abroad as natural, tobacco-free and even therapeutic alternatives to conventional cigarettes, are not safer than regular tobacco cigarettes.



ADMISSION ALERT

MTECH IN COMPUTER SCIENCE & ENGINEERING

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Netaji Subhash Engineering College, one of the premier engineering colleges in Kolkata, is offering MTech in various fields of engineering and technology for 2026. Admissions are open now. Those interested, can opt for MTech degrees in Computer Science & Engineering, Electronics & Communication Engineering, Control

& Instrumentation Engineering and Power Systems. The Kolkata-based engineering college offers advanced research and innovation opportunities, industry-oriented curriculum, modern laboratories and infrastructure, experienced faculty and research guidance, hands-on project development, strong academic and industry exposure and career advancement opportunities.

AI-DRIVEN WORKPLACE SPURS DEMAND FOR INDUSTRY-RELEVANT SKILLS

For job seekers, continuous learning, hands-on experience and the ability to work with AI will matter more in 2026

ADRITA BHATTACHARYA

The rise of Artificial Intelligence (AI), Large Language Models (LLMs), Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG), automation and cloud technologies is transforming how businesses operate. As a result, professionals are expected to continuously learn new tools, frameworks and workflows to stay competitive in the job market. In today's rapidly evolving AI-driven world, continuous upskilling and reskilling are no longer optional; they are a must. If you think you are 'qualified' enough, you are in the wrong era. In this age of AI, more than degrees, it is your skill set that matters. Across industries, employers are increasingly focusing on practical capabilities, adaptability and real-world problem-solving skills rather than relying solely on traditional academic qualifications.

Today, employers highly value candidates who actively invest in learning and demonstrate initiative through certifications, projects, internships and practical applications of AI technologies. According to the latest Indeed-Nasscom report, India's AI Talent Inflection Point: From Skill Gaps to Competitive Advantage, 86% of



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employers have seen AI impact job roles and responsibilities, while 35% report significant redefinition or transformation. Nearly all organisations expect their 2026 workforce strategy to centre around AI-related or AI-supported roles, with 40% anticipating a major restructuring. Kolkata-based Sounak Nandi, a lead test automation engineer, does not mince words when he says that continuous upskilling and reskilling are important because they help professionals adapt to rapidly changing technologies and business requirements, build practical knowledge in AI implementation and integration, and improve employability. According to him, some of the most in-demand skills today include proficiency in AI and Generative AI, LLMs and RAG. "In the modern AI

landscape, continuous learning is becoming one of the most important professional qualities. Individuals who regularly upgrade their skills and stay updated with emerging technologies are better prepared to adapt, innovate and succeed in the future workforce," he said.

Kolkata-based Deeptiman Halder, who works in Cognizant's AIA MDM department, said that employers across industries in the current job market are primarily looking for skills in automation and workflow engineering, including process automation, API integration, AI workflow building and robotic process automation. The Indeed-Nasscom report shows that 40% of employers prefer demonstrable AI skills or certifications over degrees, while another 32% give equal weight to skills, certifications and degrees. "Cloud certifications, ETL courses and automation certifications were helpful in my case," said Halder.

According to Sashi Kumar, Managing Director, Indeed India, AI is no longer limited to specialist technol-

ogy roles. It is changing how work is designed across industries, and employers are responding by hiring for demonstrable skills, certifications and practical capability. "For job seekers, the message is clear: continuous learning, hands-on experience and the ability to work with AI will matter more in 2026," he said.

The Indeed-Nasscom report also highlights that India has seen a 103% increase in internship postings over the past three years, reflecting a stronger employer focus on hands-on learning and early talent development. Some of the top skills sought in interns include communication skills, English proficiency, keyword research, analytical skills and Python programming.

Samyo Ghosh, a third-year BTech student from Netaji Subhash Engineering College, Kolkata, believes that employers mainly look for AI literacy, problem-solving skills, communication skills, data analysis capabilities, an automation mindset and adaptability. He also believes that internships boost a candidate's CV.

TOP SKILLS IN DEMAND ACROSS INDUSTRIES

- » Cloud and infrastructure integration
- » Gen AI and LLMs, including prompt engineering
- » MLOps and deployment
- » Data analytics and visualisation

TOP AI ROLE CATEGORIES ACROSS INDUSTRIES

- » AI engineering and development
- » AI operations and enablement
- » Infrastructure and data systems

TOP SKILLS IN DEMAND IN TECH SECTOR

- » AI
- » Python
- » Machine learning
- » Azure
- » TensorFlow

BEYOND CAMPUS



Indian Air Force signed three contracts recently with IIT Bombay towards adoption of predictive maintenance for IAF's Su-30 MKI aircraft



As part of the platinum jubilee celebrations of IIT Kharagpur, the institute hosted the 11th International Convention of SPIC MACAY from, bringing together artists, scholars, and students from across India and abroad for a unique week-long cultural immersion rooted in India's timeless cultural heritage.



Trending COURSES

MA IN DIGITAL HUMANITIES AND CULTURE FROM UNIVERSITY OF LEEDS

OUR CORRESPONDENT

The University of Leeds, one of the leading institutions in the UK, is inviting applications for its MA in Digital Humanities and Culture for the September 2026 intake. The course draws on the university's wide-ranging expertise in digital arts, humanities, and cultural industries and provides students with the opportunity to work with the unique historical and cultural collections at the Brotherton Li-

brary. The programme offers opportunities for collaboration with internal and external partners, a flexible research- and practice-led curriculum spanning cutting-edge areas of digital humanities and culture, and a distinctive mix of modules from across the University. Specialist support is provided through the digital cultures and creativity hub, the digital education team, and dedicated campus workspaces with advanced digital equipment such as HELIX.

WORLD ENVIRONMENT DAY

DEMAND FOR GREEN SKILLS INCREASING

Green hiring grew 7.7% between 2024 and 2025

OUR CORRESPONDENT

India's coastal regions are facing an imminent climate crisis that will reshape lives, livelihoods and ecosystems within the next couple of decades, according to the Indian Coastal Region: Climate Projections 2021-2040 report released by Azim Premji University, Bengaluru. The report warns that the window for adaptation is rapidly narrowing, as the 1.5°C warming threshold is expected to be reached across India's administrative regions in the near future. Meanwhile, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has said that the El Nino effect could pose a risk to farm output in 2026-27. From severe heat waves to forecasts of a weakened monsoon this year, the effects of El Nino are already being felt. Though climate change is

an established scientific fact, we seem to care less about the planet and more about setting the right temperature on our air conditioners. If we do not get serious now, chances are that we will find ourselves in a much messier situation in the years ahead.

Careers in sustainability and climate change are experiencing exponential growth, driven by tightening ESG (Environmental, Social and Governance) regulations and global net-zero goals. Whether you have a technical or business background, the transition to a green economy has created massive demand for specialised, high-impact roles. The rising interest in green jobs is a silver lining amid the climate crisis. According to the International Labour Organization (ILO), green jobs are decent jobs that contribute to preserving or restoring the environment, whether in traditional sectors such as manufacturing and construction or in emerging sectors such as renewable energy and energy efficiency. According to reports, green hiring grew 7.7% between 2024 and 2025, which shows the rise of the green workforce.



Other career options in the sustainable development sector include environmental engineer, air quality engineer, energy manager, sustainability engineer, ecologist and environmental scientist

Several career options in sustainability are attracting young professionals in this scenario. Take the example of an urban planner. Urban planners help organisations develop plans for the efficient use of land and other resources to create an ecologically balanced

environment. In an era of booming real estate development, urban planning has emerged as one of the most sought-after careers in the sustainability domain.

One can also opt to become a landscape architect. These professionals design eco-friendly, problem-solving projects that support and enhance the natural environment. Many commercial, residential and office projects are hiring landscape architects to help blend built structures with nature.

Other career options in the sustainable development sector include environmental engineer, air quality engineer, energy manager, sustainability engineer, ecologist and environmental scientist.

With the United Nations' Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) serving as a universal blueprint for development, green career opportunities such as ESG analyst, carbon accountant and renewable energy engineer are increasingly in demand.



BLACKBOARD

Ireland's University of Galway and Presidency University, Bengaluru recently held strategic discussions to explore academic collaboration opportunities and strengthen international learning pathways for Indian students interested in pursuing higher education opportunities in Ireland.

IIT Allahabad, an institute of national importance, has signed a MoU with TeamLease EdTech Ltd as the technology service provider for its Executive MTEch in Artificial Intelligence and Data Science in online mode.

Researchers from the Department of Biotechnology and Medical Engineering at NIT Rourkela have developed an AI-enabled autofocusing technology that can improve microscopic imaging for biomedical diagnostic applications. The technology is capable of producing rapid, accurate, and repeatable results with minimal human intervention.